

The Logic of War and Its Prospects

Zhihu column · 2026-01-11

Eighty years have passed since the end of the Second World War. Eighty years is the span of three or four generations, so large-scale war — the global conflagrations that fed millions into the meat grinder — seems to belong to a bygone age. The terror of the nuclear balance, and the productive forces developed worldwide by a new round of globalization, made "peace and development" the theme of the age. Apart from small, short wars, a great and protracted war appeared impossible.

Yet all this seems to be changing. The superpower is fomenting wars everywhere, and every force is preparing for battle; at this very moment three wars are being fought — Russia–Ukraine, Gaza, Venezuela. Is humanity repeating history, marching toward mutual slaughter? This is the question everyone who cares about the fate of human society wants answered. This article attempts, on the basis of the theories of the classical Marxist writers, academic papers, and news material, to explore it.

I. The Fundamental Causes of War

In the first half of the twentieth century, humanity experienced two world wars within barely twenty years. This cannot help making people feel that our society must contain some inner logic that makes war frequent. On this point, the classical Marxist writers gave the most widely accepted explanation of the twentieth century.

This book proves that the war of 1914–1918 was, on both sides, an imperialist (i.e., an annexationist, predatory, brigand) war for the division of the world, for the partition and repartition of colonies, of "spheres of influence" of finance capital, etc. — Lenin, *Imperialism, the Highest Stage of Capitalism*

The causes of World War I and World War II can be fully explained by Lenin's view in *Imperialism*: the First World War was fought to re-divide colonies, and the Second World War to re-divide colonies again. But by 2025 — decades after the independence wave of Asian and African colonies (the last colony to gain independence was Namibia), when almost all countries are sovereign nation-states — the language of dividing colonies seems no longer applicable.

After World War II, the United States led the construction of the economic and political order of the global capitalist system. Under this order, apart from Israel — that criminal settler colonialism — no new colonial countries appeared. It seemed that all the bourgeois nation-states of the world had

formed an alliance: so long as the capitalist economic order based on "private property" was protected, everyone could live in peace. In reality, the postwar capitalist world-system enjoyed such a long overall peace because it had indeed developed a new mode of the division of labor. On this, China's rulers at the time had a clear-headed understanding.

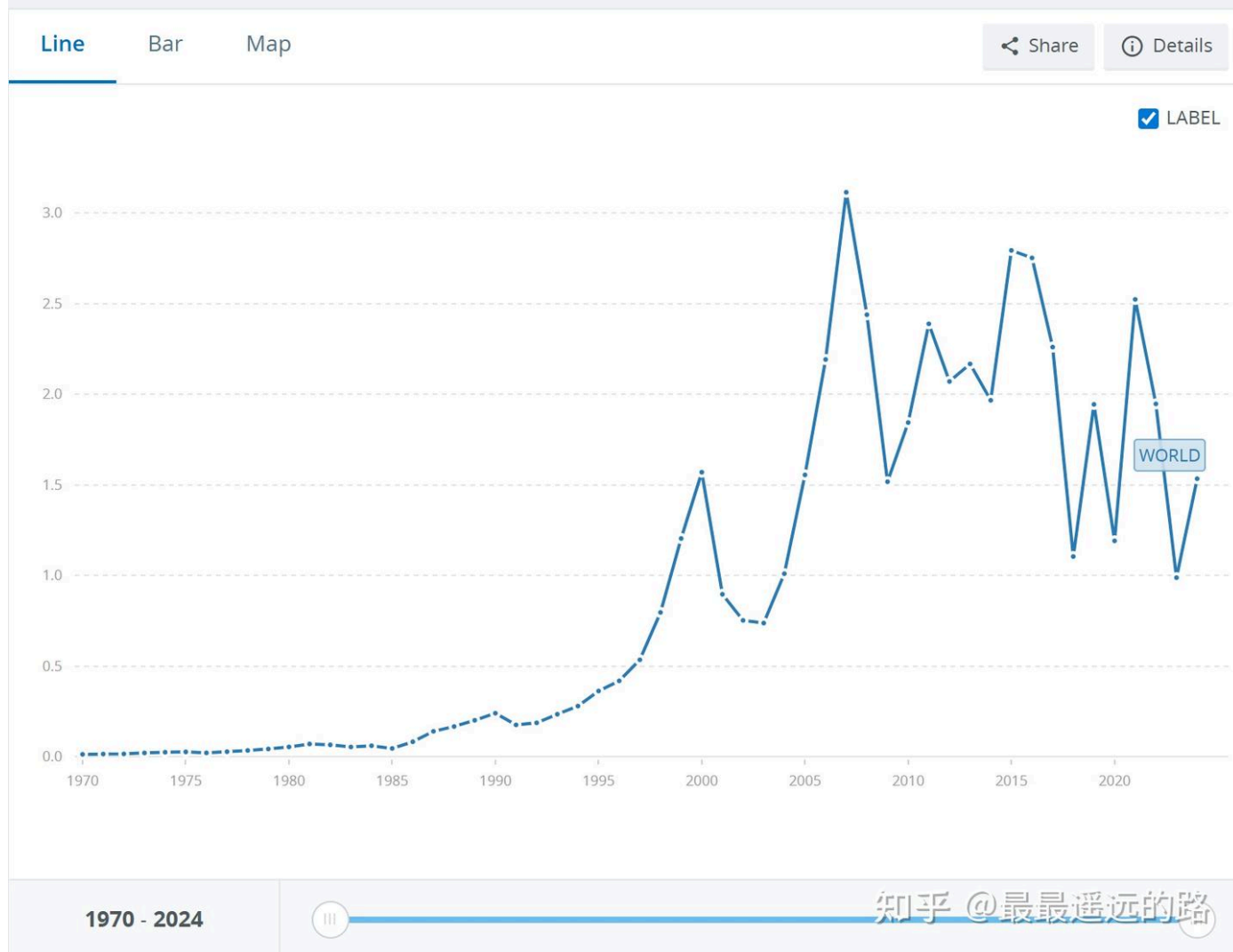
The truly major problems in the world today, the strategic problems of global significance, are two: the problem of peace and the problem of economy, or development. The peace problem is the East–West problem; the development problem is the North–South problem. In a word, "East, West, South, North." The North–South problem is the core. The developed countries of Europe, America, and Japan — as they continue to develop, what problems do they face? Your capital needs an outlet, your trade needs an outlet, your markets need an outlet; unless this problem is solved, your development will always be constrained... It is hard to say that the continued development of these one-point-one or one-point-two billion people can be built on the continued poverty of three billion others... Most countries remain in extreme poverty; unless their economic problems are solved, neither the development of the Third World nor the continued development of the developed countries will be easy... Some developed countries worry that if China develops and exports more goods, will it affect the exports of the developed countries? There is indeed a competition problem. But the developed countries lead in technology and have more high-end goods — what is there to fear! In short, if the South does not develop properly, the outlets for the North's capital and goods are very limited; if the South remains poor, the North may have no way out. So I consider the positive attitude of Japanese business circles toward the development of Sino-Japanese economic and technological cooperation a decision with strategic vision. — Deng Xiaoping, from his conversation with the visiting delegation of the Japan Chamber of Commerce and Industry, "Peace and Development Are the Two Major Problems of the Contemporary World," *Selected Works of Deng Xiaoping*, Vol. 3, 1985

To sum up: the way the postwar capitalist countries resolved their contradictions was to let the capital of the advanced countries flow out to the backward countries, expanding the market size of the capitalist world. In the world market, the division of labor between advanced and backward countries changed: formerly the backward countries supplied primary products (agriculture and mining) and the advanced countries supplied manufactured goods; now the backward countries supply low-technology industrial products and the advanced countries supply advanced industrial products. Through this new division of labor, the advanced countries can transfer part of their "backward capacity" or "low-end industries" to the backward countries, upgrade their own industries, and develop high-end manufacturing, services, and finance; while the backward countries, escaping the permanent condition of agrarian states, can achieve rapid industrialization by receiving the capital of the advanced countries.

Foreign direct investment, net inflows (BoP, current US\$)

Balance of Payments database, International Monetary Fund (IMF), note: International Monetary Fund, Balance of Payments database, supplemented by data from the United Nations Conference on Trade and Development and official national sources.; UN Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD); Official national sources

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Global FDI exploded after 1985, from \$50 billion before 1980 to \$3 trillion in 2007, staying above \$1.5 trillion in 2024.

Source: <https://data.worldbank.org/indicator/BX.KLT.DINV.WD.GD.ZS>

From the 1980s on, Japanese firms, long squeezed by the United States, exported industry to China on a large scale after reaching a "peaceful alliance" consensus with China's top leadership; Japan was the largest source of FDI in the early reform era. The firms that moved to China bought components and advanced equipment from Japan, promoting the industrial upgrading of Japanese firms at home.

The appreciation of the yen meant lower costs for Japan's outward direct investment; combined with heavy domestic regulation, high operating costs, and a saturating market at home, Japanese manufacturers began relocating production overseas on a large scale. China had only recently opened up: labor and raw material costs were low, the market vast, the location close to Japan, and

preferential policies were offered to foreign investors. China thus became an important destination for Japanese corporate investment, and Japanese manufacturing saw its first wave of investment in China. During this period Japanese direct investment in China concentrated in the coastal special economic zones, on a fairly limited scale: actual investment from 1979 to 1990 totaled \$2.99 billion, yet because all foreign direct investment in China was still in the exploratory stage, this was 14.5 percent of the total. In the early 1990s, with China's establishment of the socialist market economy as a reform goal and rapid growth, Sino-Japanese economic cooperation reached a new level and Japanese firms launched a new wave of investment in China. From 1991 to 1996, Japanese direct investment in China grew at about 40 percent per year; actual investment in 1995 reached \$3.11 billion, exceeding the cumulative total of 1990. The expanding direct investment drove Japanese exports of machinery, raw materials, and components to China, and "reverse imports," boosting bilateral trade. In 1996, Sino-Japanese goods trade reached \$62.43 billion, about double the 1993 level, far above the roughly \$1.1 billion at the time of normalization. After the 1997 Asian financial crisis, Japan's economy sank, corporate earnings fell, and Japanese direct investment in China dipped; actual investment in 2000 was \$2.92 billion. Source: Xu Mei, researcher at the Institute of Japanese Studies, Chinese Academy of Social Sciences, "Japan's Direct Investment in China: 50 Years of Sino-Japanese Diplomatic Relations, Retrospect, Reflections, and Prospects"

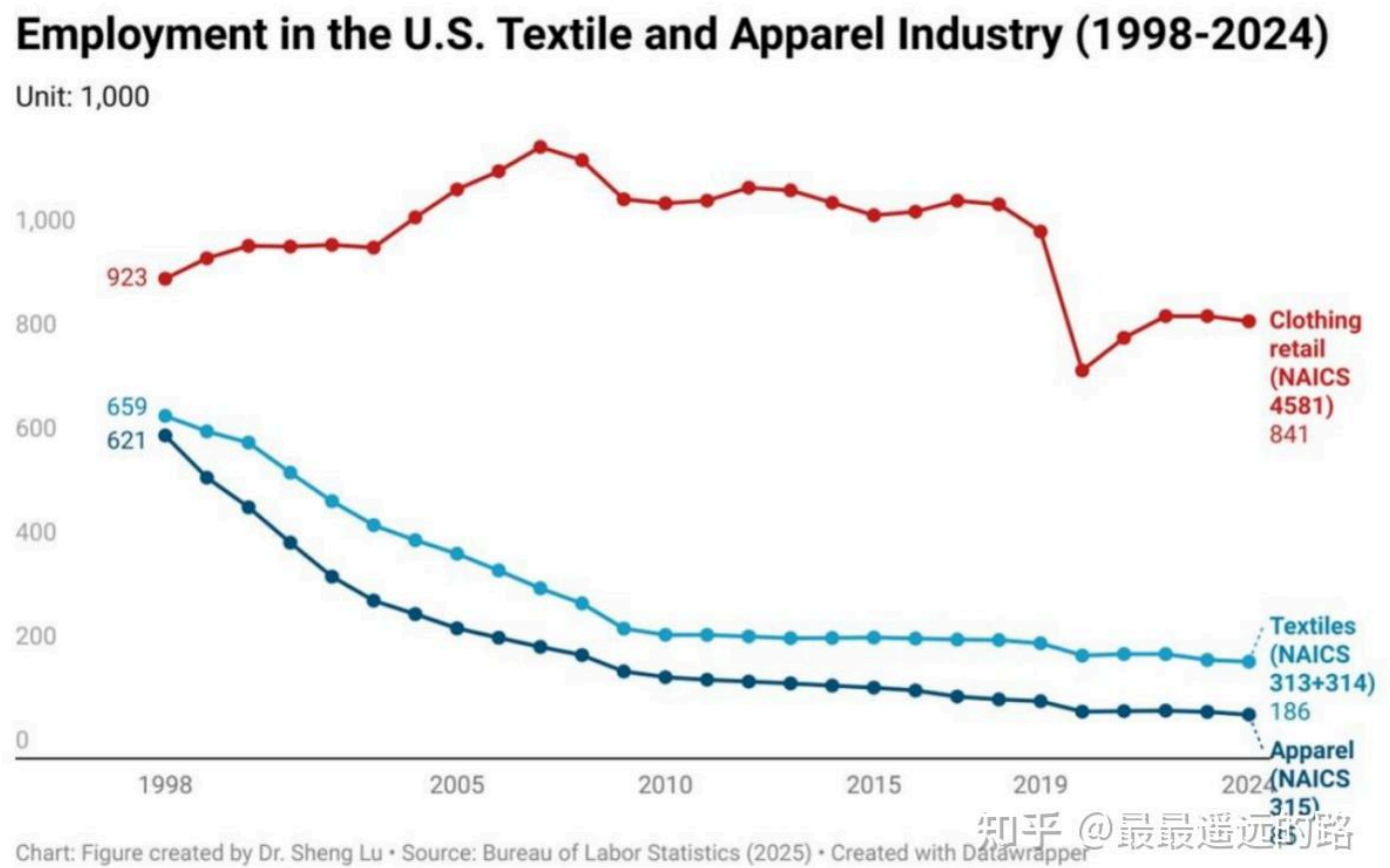
表1 日本对华直接投资发展状况		
年	日本对华直接投资实际投入	
	金额 (亿美元)	在外国对华直接投资实际 投入额中所占比重(%)
1979—1990	29.9	14.5
1995	31.1	8.3
2000	29.2	7.2
2005	65.3	9.0
2010	40.8	3.6
2011	63.5	5.1
2012	73.5	6.1
2013	70.6	5.7
2014	43.3	3.4
2015	31.9	

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Source: <https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/yn7cbWt-RuHlZZBXBnJJ8g>

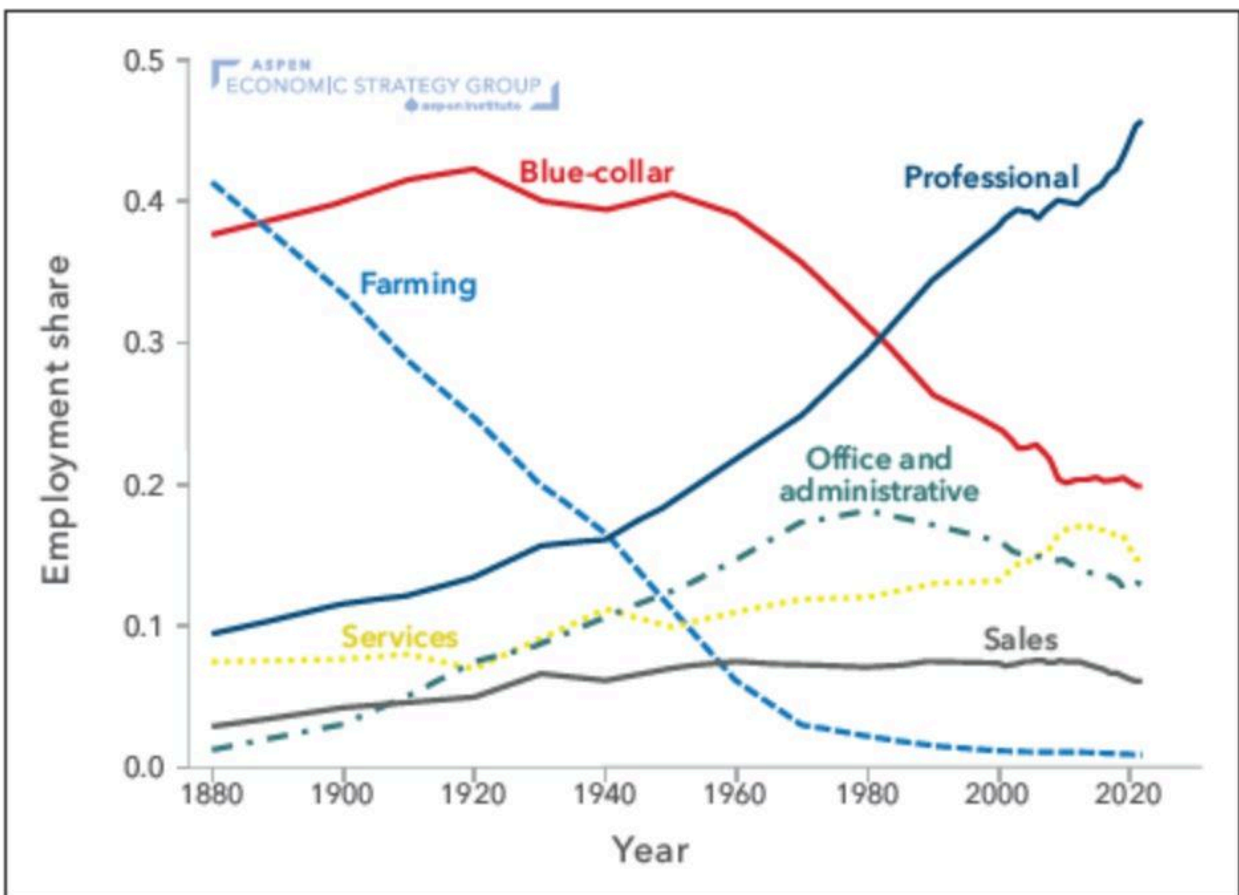
The bourgeoisie of the advanced countries could obtain an endless supply of cheap labor and a rapidly expanding market in the backward countries; at the same time, at home, they could change the class structure and the balance of class forces by changing the industrial structure — reducing the

number of combative factory workers and increasing the number of tamer office white-collar workers, stabilizing bourgeois rule. Two birds with one stone.



The number of apparel and textile workers in the US. In the 1990s the US still had many apparel and textile workers; now few remain. Clothing retail, which must be local, has changed little

Figure 1: Changes in the occupation structure of the US labor market, 1880-2024



Notes: Calculations are based on decadal US census data from 1880 to 2000 (except for 1890) and 2001-2022 American Community Survey (ACS) samples (except for 2020), sourced via the Integrated Public Use Microdata Series (IPUMS) (Ruggles et al. 2024). Occupations are harmonized across decades to two-digit SOC codes using the IPUMS occ1950 encoding and methodology used in Autor and Dorn 2013; a detailed methodology is described in the data appendix. Samples are restricted to workers aged 18 to 64 in noninstitutional quarters who provide non-military occupational responses. See the appendix for exhaustive definitions of each category.

In the postwar US, white-collar workers gradually outnumbered blue-collar. After the 1980s, blue-collar jobs moved on a large scale to Third World countries, and the American working class became predominantly non-blue-collar. Source:

<https://conversableeconomist.com/2024/12/12/the-changing-us-labor-market/>

The governments of the backward countries gained large tax revenues and the foreign exchange needed for domestic development (expanded domestic reproduction requires foreign exchange to import advanced machinery, equipment, and technology from abroad). The peasant masses, the majority in backward countries, could raise their living standards by working in factories. So most people in the backward countries benefited in some measure (see the author's other answer: "How do you view the domestic fundamentals?"). The losers were the factory workers of the advanced countries who could not transition into high-end industries, and their bourgeoisie; and in the backward countries, the workers and capitalists of some advanced industries developed through import substitution and the like.



Note: For the least developed countries, the real annual gross domestic product (GDP) growth rate is shown instead of real GDP per capita growth. Aggregates are derived using PPP exchange rates.
Source: ILO calculations based on UNDESA (2017) and IMF (2018).

Per-capita GDP growth after 2000: growth in non-high-income countries is clearly higher overall than in high-income countries. https://www.researchgate.net/figure/Annual-growth-rate-of-real-GDP-per-capita-global-and-by-country-income-group-2000-18_fig1_334068315

Fastest Growing Economies in 2024

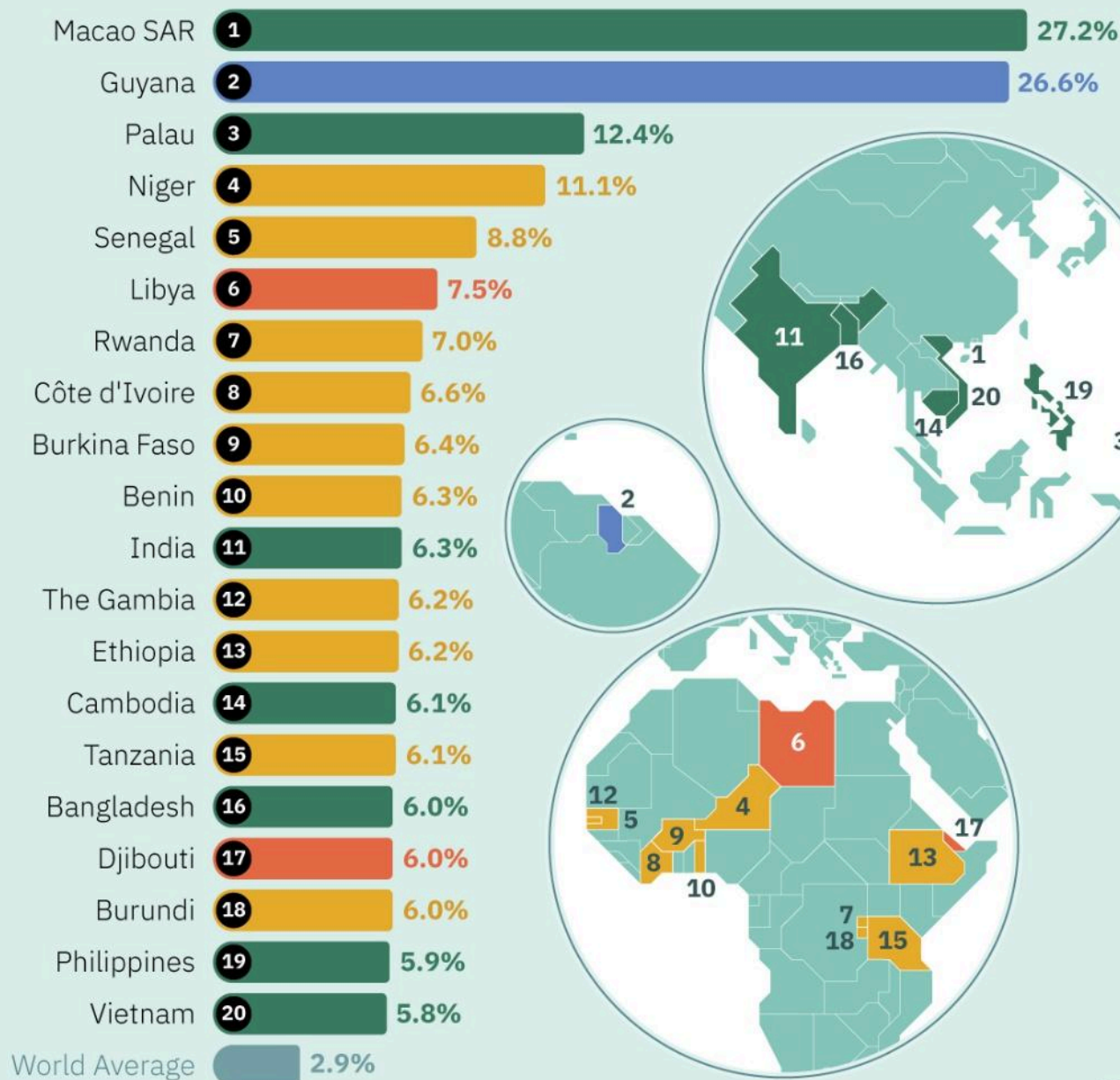
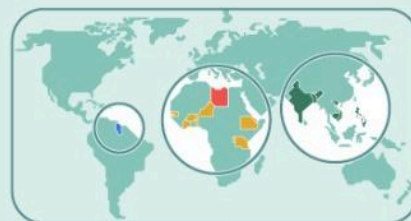
Real GDP growth projections

Asia Pacific

Sub-Saharan Africa

Americas

Middle East and North Africa



Source: IMF (Oct 2023)

For India, data and forecasts are presented on a fiscal year basis (April to March).

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The world's fastest-growing economies are almost all non-high-income countries. Source:

<https://www.visualcapitalist.com/ranked-the-fastest-growing-economies-in-2024/>

At the same time, by exporting capital to the backward industrial countries, the advanced industrial countries expanded the global market and weakened trade conflicts among themselves. Rather, their common position opposite the backward industrial countries within the capitalist system allowed them to unite, prolonging their advantage as long as possible in order to keep draining surplus value from the backward industrial countries. So within the great alliance between the advanced industrial countries and the not-yet-industrialized backward industrial countries, there also exists a small alliance among the advanced industrial countries themselves.

This model has been given a new name in the discourse of Marxist theorists: "new imperialism." Clearly, the author is critical of this new imperialism, correctly recognizing that it has not escaped the political form of the nation-state, but also genuinely acknowledging the basic fact that economic globalization is the core of the new imperialist model. Yet the author emphasizes the harms of capital globalization to the Third World countries and finds it hard to explain: if it is all harm and no benefit, why did this model spread across the vast Global South, and why — in the countries receiving the most capital (China, Vietnam, etc.) — did not only the bourgeois state but the broad peasant masses as a whole support the process? If the imperial "center" and the imperial "periphery" had no common interest — even relative and temporary — in this model, how can one explain the long peace among the nation-states of the world?

Anyone discussing the question of American "imperialism" is easily challenged: the United States directly rules or occupies no country, in no region of the world... Today, when a strong country makes war on a weak one, we can only understand it thus: the use of force is not an imperialist act but a neutral act, carried out in the interests of the "international community." There followed a period we call "globalization" — the internationalization of capital — including the free, rapid flow of capital worldwide and the most predatory financial speculation. This, like many other events, was not a response to capitalism's success but to its failure. The US used its control mechanisms over the financial and commercial networks to postpone the day of reckoning for its domestic capital, shifting the pressure elsewhere and easing the flow of surplus capital that seeks profit everywhere and engages in frantic financial speculation. In the subsequent "Washington Consensus," through the IMF and the World Bank, the imperial regime demanded "structural adjustment" and used various means to make these economies more vulnerable to the pressure of American-led global capital: for instance, emphasizing export-oriented production and removing import restrictions, making producers market-dependent for their survival, especially in agriculture when open markets exposed them to competition from heavily subsidized Western producers; privatizing public services, which would be so fragile that companies backed by the major capitalist powers could easily replace them; high interest rates and financial deregulation created huge gains for American owners while causing debt crises in the Third World (ultimately manifesting one of capitalism's inherent contradictions, the decline of capitalism at

the imperial center); and so on. At the international level, the state remains crucial. The new imperialism, compared with the older colonial imperial forms, depends more than ever on a system of multiple, more or less sovereign nation-states. The fact that "globalization" extends the pure economic power of capital beyond any single nation-state in itself means that global capital requires many nation-states to exercise the functions of administration and coercion that sustain its property system and provide the compatible rules, credibility environment, and legal order — no credible form of "global rule" can provide the daily order or conditions of accumulation capital demands. — Ellen Wood, *Empire of Capital* (original English edition 2003)

This alliance between the advanced and backward industrial countries is most visible in China, the largest recipient of global FDI. As a nation-state, China long provided global capital with a rapidly expanding market, a vast labor supply, and stable class relations, allowing the surplus capital of the advanced industrial countries to keep flowing in and reproduce itself, while its own advanced industries developed along with the development of China's mid- and low-end industries. This alliance meant that even when China became the world's largest industrial country (2010), the developed countries took no action against it but continued to invest. But this alliance was not eternal; after China proposed the Belt and Road Initiative and "Made in China 2025," it began to break apart. On this point, Lenin's critique of Kautsky also contains a valuable elaboration. The alliance Lenin spoke of — among industrial countries dividing up colonial and semi-colonial countries — is not the same thing as the "alliance" between advanced and backward industrial countries in the twenty-first century discussed here. But on the question of the necessary transition from a "peaceful alliance" to war, it still has direct relevance today.

The "peaceful" alliance prepares war, and in turn grows out of war; the two condition each other, producing, on the same basis of imperialist ties and interrelations in world economics and world politics, an alternation of peaceful and non-peaceful forms of struggle. The super-clever Kautsky, to reassure the workers and reconcile them with the social-chauvinists who have gone over to the bourgeoisie, separates one link of the chain from another, separates today's peaceful (and ultra-imperialist, even ultra-ultra-imperialist) alliance of all the great powers for the "pacification" of China (remember the suppression of the Boxer Rebellion) from tomorrow's non-peaceful conflict, which again prepares the "peaceful" general alliance for the partition, say, of Turkey, and so on. Kautsky, instead of showing the workers the living connection between the imperialist period of peace and the imperialist period of war, offers them the dead abstraction, to reconcile them with their dead leaders. — Lenin, *Imperialism, the Highest Stage of Capitalism*

The transfer of mid- and low-end industries dominated by factory workers from the advanced capitalist industrial countries was essentially complete by the 2010s. And China was already moving into high-end manufacturing in the 2010s, beginning to shake the foundation of its alliance with the former developed countries. The period of peace is drawing to a close, and the period of war has

begun. The advanced industrial countries formed an alliance to encircle China's industrial upgrading, most characteristically by banning lithography machine exports to block China's R&D of advanced chip processes. To date China has not broken through EUV lithography (no public announcement), showing the ban has had effect. But China is after all an industrial hegemon: through domestic enterprise efforts, it has still achieved mass production of 7nm and 5nm chips with DUV machines.

The industry and technology of the advanced industrial countries advance slowly; those of the backward countries advance quickly. Uneven development is therefore inevitable in capitalist production. And when this unevenness grows to a certain degree, the side originally in the advanced position in the alliance (America, Japan, Europe) and the side originally backward (China) are driven toward competition. And competition creates the conditions for war.

Since there are still many backward industrial countries in the world, the formation of new alliances remains possible (see the author's other article: "Can the World Make Room for a Developed China?"). Whether this competition necessarily leads to war depends on the calculations of the various nation-states themselves.

Some countries, because of their position in the original system, their own strength, and their geopolitics, may choose to reach a peaceful alliance with China, merging production chains and jointly developing third-country markets (e.g., South Korea; see the author's relevant answers on the four chaebol heads appearing together in Beijing and what Lee Jae-myung's visit might bring).

Others, because their threatened special interests are so great (the dollar as world currency, and control of nearly all international economic organizations), tend more toward confrontation (e.g., the United States; see the author's answers on the US seizing an oil tanker escorted by Russian submarines and the signals it sends, and other answers in the "Multipolar World Analysis" column).

Still others waver between the two, like the EU. Toward such wavering countries, China hopes to form a union, together with the South, into a new peaceful alliance, and is therefore exerting itself to win over the EU (see "Has China given up on winning over the EU?"). The following article from China's official media is a kind of public appeal — indeed, such appeals have been made through various channels for a long time.

What Europe should really ask itself is: as an important pole of the multipolar world, how should Europe define itself? Some Europeans are like "geopolitical actuaries," seeming very clever, but precisely miscalculating. On matters of principle, if Europe keeps appeasing and compromising with hegemonic behavior, trading away basic morality and conscience as commodities, and putting Washington's likes and dislikes first, that is undoubtedly "tacit consent and complicity" with hegemonism and power politics. The consequences of unprincipled compromise come so fast: as Greenland faces the threat of seizure, Europe is swallowing the bitter fruit. In pursuing strategic autonomy, Europe is by no means without cards to play. As one of the world's largest economies, the

EU possesses a huge internal market, an advanced industrial system, and a deep multilateralist tradition — the real foundation of its resistance to hegemony. Economically, Europe can deepen internal market integration, throw off excessive dependence on the American financial system, and advance the internationalization of the euro; in energy, adhere to a strategy of diversified cooperation and speed up renewables; in diplomacy, abandon the mindset of "drawing lines by ideology" and strengthen cooperation with China and other emerging-market countries to build a multipolar diplomatic order. With a longer view, Europe is far from having "walked into a dead end." Source: Facing hegemonic coercion, Europe can no longer pretend to sleep

So China's industrial upgrading and large-scale capital export — or simply, China's rise — broke the original "peaceful alliance," and this rupture is the fundamental cause of today's world entering a turbulent "period of war." The aims of war are the contest for high-end industry markets, space for capital export, and financial control of the global capitalist system (dollar hegemony). On this logic, what is happening in Latin America becomes easy to understand.

Although Chinese enterprises' direct investment in Latin America declined in 2023, the overall trend of the last decade has been growth, with good results in both quality and efficiency, showing the characteristics of high-quality development and promoting the region's economic and social progress. Chinese enterprises' annual direct investment in Latin America rose from \$280 million in 2003 to \$8.74 billion in 2023, an average annual growth of about 18.77 percent, reaching \$19.23 billion in 2019. Latin America has become an important destination for Chinese outward direct investment; though disturbed by international protectionism and hegemonism, the momentum of Chinese investment in the region remains strong, reflecting the good development of high-quality Belt and Road cooperation between China and Latin America and the deepening and resilience of Chinese enterprises' globalization strategy... By sector, the share of Chinese investment in raw materials fell sharply, from 94.81 percent in 2005–2009 to 41.96 percent in 2020–2023. Meanwhile, the share of investment aimed at the domestic markets of Latin America and the Caribbean reached 32.78 percent in 2020–2023, and manufacturing's share rose to 22.72 percent, showing diversification. Although investment in metals, minerals, and mining still holds a large share (34.22 percent in 2020–2023), it is far below the 81.41 percent of 2005–2009. Energy and the automotive and auto-parts industries have shown marked growth momentum over the past decade, becoming among the most active areas of Chinese investment; energy has largely shifted to non-fossil sources, reflecting the green trend of Chinese investment. Since 2020, the share of Chinese investment in Latin American non-fossil energy projects has risen 10 percentage points. Autos and auto parts have become a new hotspot of Chinese direct investment in the region, with over \$2 billion in Mexico and Brazil. Chinese investment in new-energy vehicles and auto parts not only advances the local auto industry but is gradually forming a Latin American auto-parts chain, driving long-term economic growth and employment in the region. Source: China–Latin America economic and trade special topic | New characteristics, trends, and theoretical implications of Chinese enterprises' direct investment in Latin America

Although the global trade pattern has been reshaped, the American supply chain remains deeply embedded in China's manufacturing system, and China's position as the core supplier of Mexican intermediates has markedly strengthened; China–Mexico supply-chain synergy continues to deepen. Because Mexico's domestic supply chain is underdeveloped, the Chinese value-added content of its manufacturing exports to the US keeps rising. In autos, electronics and appliances, medical devices, and other fields, Mexico imports large quantities of Chinese components and raw materials, assembles them locally, and exports to the US. This stems on one hand from Chinese firms investing in Mexico to integrate into North American supply chains, and on the other from firms proactively adjusting supply chains to use Mexico's trade advantages to evade US tariffs. Empirical research shows a significant positive correlation between Mexico's imports from China and its exports to the US (correlation coefficient $r = 0.9560$, $p < 0.01$). By integrating Chinese intermediates, Mexico achieves large-scale exports to the US and strengthens its hub role in the China–US regional value chain; China–Mexico supply-chain cooperation keeps deepening. Mexico's imports of capital goods and intermediates from China grow rapidly: from 2001 to 2024, China's share of Mexico's import market rose 19 percentage points; in 2024, Mexico's imports from China reached \$129.139 billion, up 13.6 percent year on year. By import structure, of Mexico's major imports in 2024, auto parts and accessories (\$34.331 billion) and integrated circuits (\$25.778 billion) ranked at the top, with China contributing \$4.7 billion and \$8.3 billion respectively — 14 percent and 32 percent of each category. China is also Mexico's largest semiconductor supplier, holding 43.2 percent of its import market. This evolution reflects the formation of a new division of labor — "Made in China + assembled in Mexico" — in the restructuring of North American regional supply chains. Source: Regional cooperation and integration special topic | Supply-chain transfer in US–Mexico economic integration and China's supply-chain security

China–Latin America financial cooperation has borne rich fruit. The People's Bank of China and the Central Bank of Brazil renewed their bilateral local-currency swap agreement, at 190 billion yuan. China has renewed the currency swap with Argentina four times, expanding from 70 billion to 130 billion yuan. The renminbi's share of Latin American cross-border settlement is 14 percent, nearly five times the 2019 level. Brazil, Argentina, and others are piloting renminbi settlement in bulk commodities such as iron ore and lithium. Argentina's Yuyaiyako salt-lake project locks lithium prices in pesos, 15 percent below the international market price, securing China's supply chain while creating stable foreign-exchange income for Argentina. Source: The 15th Five-Year Plan opens a new journey; Chinese enterprises' Latin American expansion enters a "golden age"

It should be noted that the alliance of developed industrial countries to maintain common interests (such as the technology alliance of developed countries against China) — this seemingly solid alliance under American leadership — will also face challenges when the more fundamental alliance between advanced and backward industrial countries in the system disintegrates. Trump's recent bullying and

squeezing of European allies, and the backlash it provoked, reflect the cracking of this alliance. On this point, Lenin's view still stands.

In the reality of capitalism (not in the vulgar petty-bourgeois fantasy of British parsons or the German "Marxist" Kautsky), the "international imperialist" or "ultra-imperialist" alliance — whatever its form, whether one imperialist alliance against another, or a general alliance of all the imperialist great powers — is inevitably nothing more than a "breathing space" between wars. The peaceful alliance prepares war, and in turn grows out of war; the two condition each other, producing, on the same basis of imperialist ties and interrelations in world economics and world politics, an alternation of peaceful and non-peaceful forms of struggle. — Lenin, Imperialism, the Highest Stage of Capitalism

II. Factors Driving War

(1) Political Polarization

As said above, the alliance among bourgeois states, now broken, still has the possibility of being reorganized — and China hopes to achieve such a reorganization to avoid war. But why do some countries prefer economic confrontation, even escalating to the means of war?

Here we must introduce another basic principle of Marxism: "the state is an instrument of exploitation of the oppressed class."

The state is by no means a force imposed on society from outside. Nor is it, as Hegel asserted, "the reality of the ethical idea," "the image and reality of reason." More precisely, the state is the product of society at a certain stage of development; it is the admission that this society has become entangled in an insoluble self-contradiction, split into irreconcilable opposites which it is powerless to dispel. To keep these opposites — classes with conflicting economic interests — from consuming themselves and society in fruitless struggle, a power apparently standing above society is needed, a power that moderates the conflict and keeps it within the bounds of "order"; this power, born of society but placing itself above it and increasingly alienating itself from it, is the state. — Engels, The Origin of the Family, Private Property and the State

When the oppressed masses grow dissatisfied with the current economic system, the exploiting class must strengthen the state apparatus and, through foreign war, deflect the resistance of the oppressed class, thereby maintaining the current exploitative system. According to the classical Marxist writers, whether the crisis of rule stems from internal class oppression or internal national oppression, the ruling class may stir up external national conflicts, even resort to war.

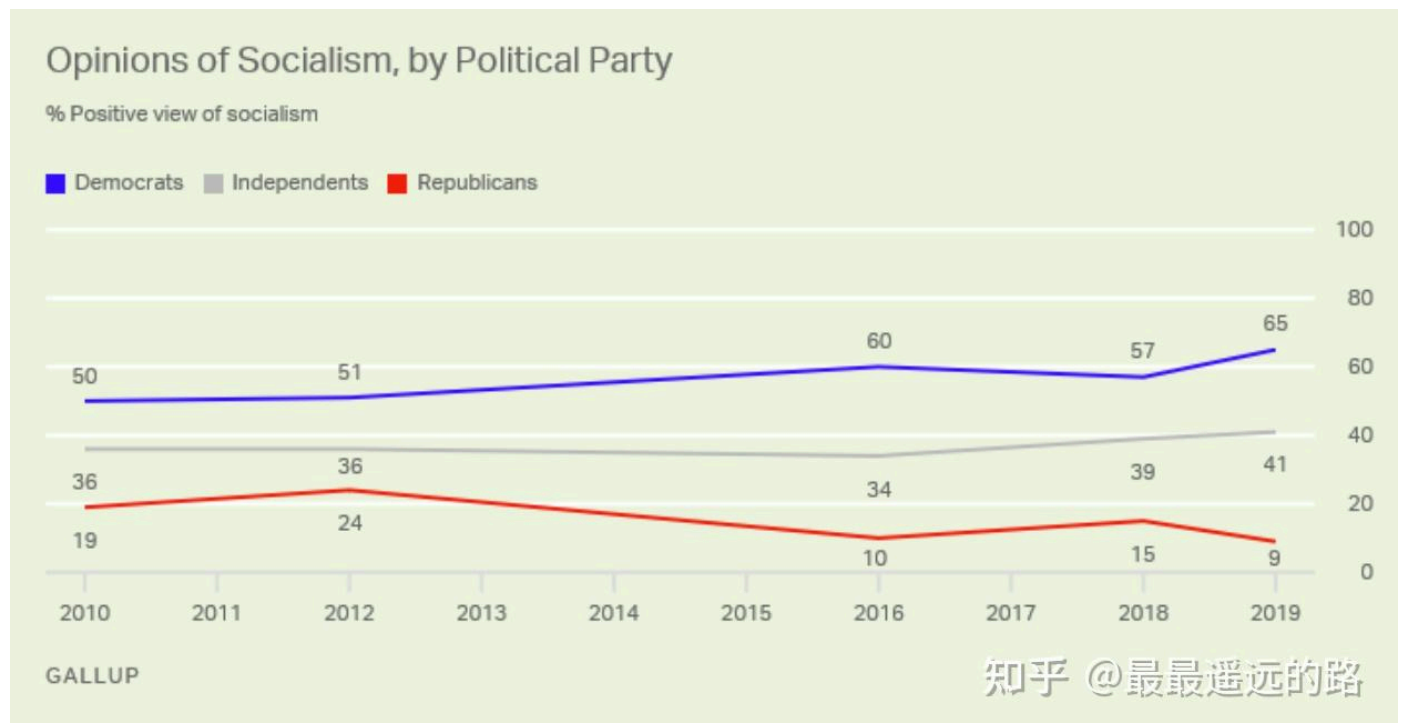
The men in high positions in old society and the ruling classes can continue to hold power and exploit the working masses only by means of national struggles and national contradictions; naturally, they all

regard the International Workingmen's Association as their common enemy. Any means is good, so long as it can destroy it. — Marx, letter to the editors of Der Volksstaat, March 23, 1871

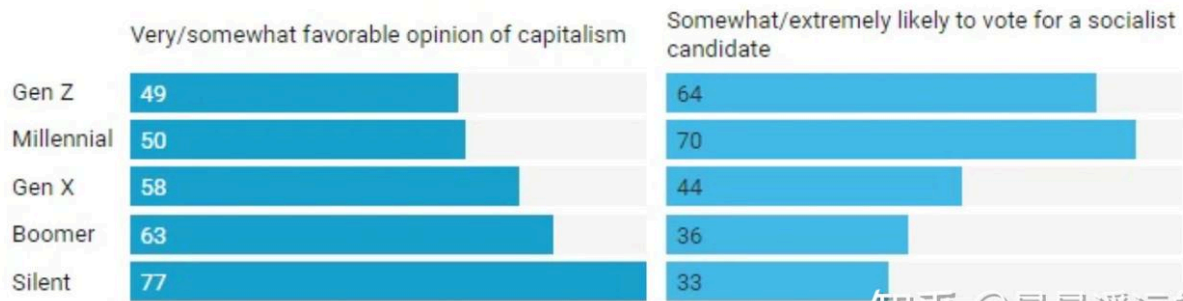
In Russia, the newest type of capital-imperialism had already shown its hand fully in the tsarist government's policy toward Persia, Manchuria, and Mongolia, but on the whole military-feudal imperialism still prevailed in Russia. Nowhere in the world was the majority of the population so oppressed as in Russia: Great Russians constituted only 43 percent of the population — less than half — and all other nationalities were treated as aliens without rights. Of Russia's 170 million people, nearly 100 million were oppressed and without rights. The tsarist government waged war to seize Galicia and completely strangle the freedom of the Ukrainians, and to seize Armenia and Constantinople. It regarded this war as a means of diverting attention from growing domestic discontent and suppressing the rising revolutionary movement. — Socialism and War: The Attitude of the RSDLP towards the War (July–August 1915)

Their claims were verified by history — and reality is verifying them again.

In the United States, since the financial crisis, support for socialism among the left-leaning Democrats has gradually increased, while opposition to socialism among the right-leaning Republicans has also increased. By age, among millennials and Gen Z under 40, who were less influenced by Cold War education, the share willing to vote for socialist candidates exceeds 60 percent. Nearly everyone who follows current events has noticed that political polarization in American society has deepened.



YouGov poll by generation



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Source: <https://www.abc.net.au/triplej/programs/hack/socialism-booming-popularity-among-young-people-survey-finds/11655582>

The impoverishment that spread after the 2008 economic crisis made more and more American working people lose faith in the capitalist system, and made it increasingly hard for the "establishment" that wished to rule normally to win working-class votes. To respond to the radicalization of the proletariat, the bourgeoisie had to abandon centrist parties and turn to fascist parties — a striking parallel to the Weimar Republic after the economic crisis. The so-called "right-wing populist" parties' support rose more than that of the so-called "left-wing populists."

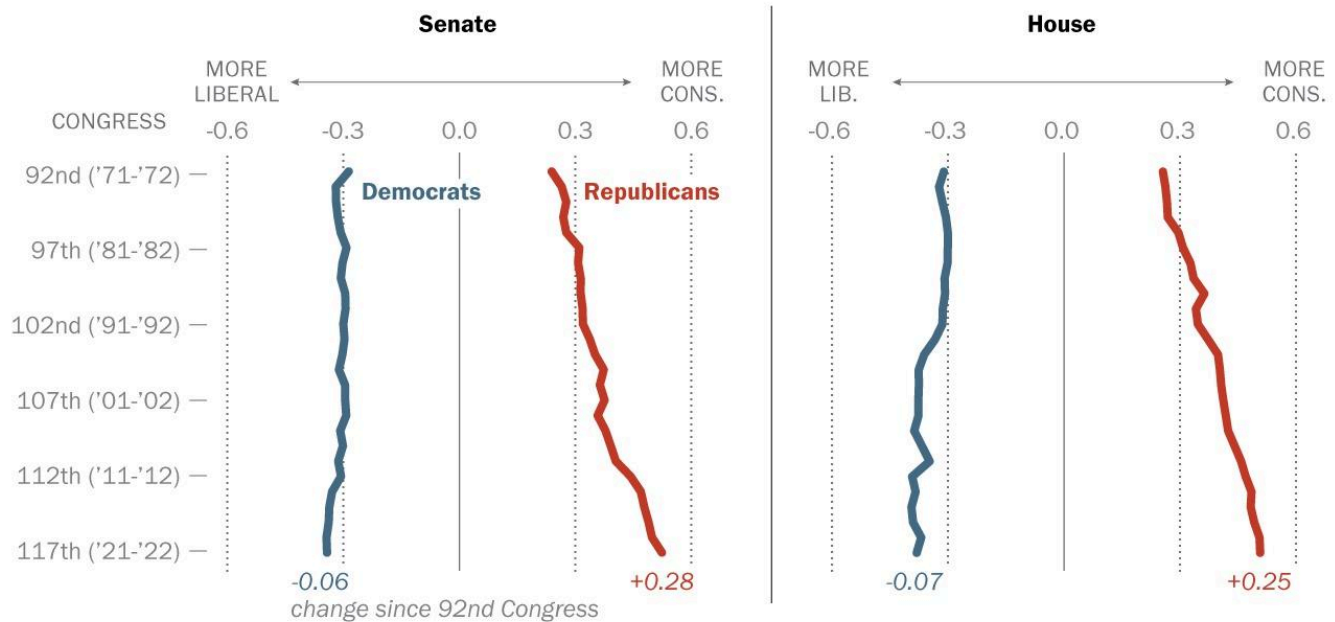
<i>Reichstag</i> Election	20 th May 1928 % vote	14 th Sept. 1930 % vote	31 st July 1932 % vote
Nazi Party	2.6	18.3	37.3
Protestant middle-class parties			
Nationalist Party	14.2	7.0	5.9
People's Party	8.7	4.5	1.2
Democratic Party	4.8	3.8	1.0
Business Party	4.9	4.0	0.3
Other parties	9.2	10.0	2.3
TOTAL	41.8	29.3	11.8
Catholic parties			
Centre Party and Bavarian People's Party	15.2	14.8	15.0
Social Democratic Party	29.8	24.5	21.6
Communist Party	10.6	13.1	14.3

German elections 1928 — 1932 @ 最遥远的路

The Communist Party's vote share rose from 10.6% to 14.3%, while the Nazi vote rose from 2.6% to 37.3%. Source:
<https://www.blacksacademy.net/pages/hy-028-hyqenr-rise-nazi-party.php>

Republicans have moved further to the right than Democrats have to the left

Average ideology of members, by Congress



Note: Data excludes nonvoting delegates, as well as lawmakers who officially served but (due to illness, resignation or other factors) didn't have a scorable voting record for a given Congress. Party categories include independents who caucus(ed) with that party. Members who changed parties (or became independents) during a Congress were classified according to the status they held the longest during that Congress. For most of the 116th Congress, Rep. Justin Amash of Michigan was either an independent or a Libertarian, and didn't caucus with either major party.

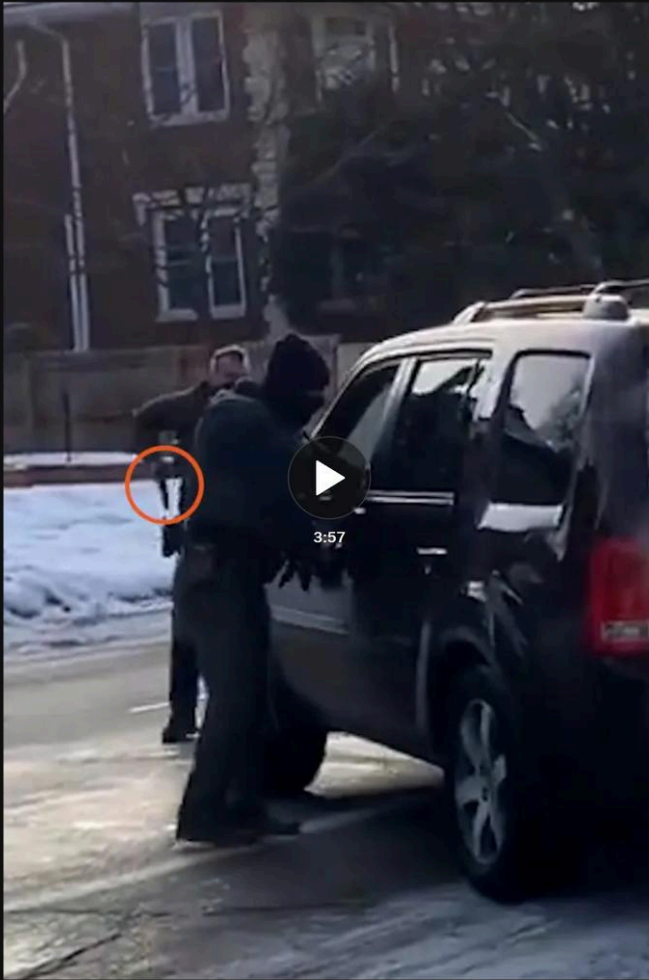
Source: Pew Research Center analysis of Voteview DW-NOMINATE data accessed on Feb. 18, 2022.

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The Republican Party's rightward shift far exceeds the Left's. Trump took over the Republicans, while the left-wing Sanders did not take over the Democrats, though he effectively won the primary in 2016. Source: <https://www.pewresearch.org/short-reads/2022/03/10/the-polarization-in-todays-congress-has-roots-that-go-back-decades/>

The main strategy of "right-wing populism" is, first, to create enemies at home (Jews/illegal immigrants) and, second, to create enemies abroad (the USSR & Britain/China) — in both cases substituting national or racial consciousness (Aryan/white supremacy) for class consciousness, to save the bourgeois state in crisis. To turn domestic contradictions into international ones, it must "seize living space." This "living space" has differed in different eras, but in essence it means grabbing things abroad — colonies, land, minerals, control of key trade routes — all of which is fundamentally a transfer of domestic contradictions. But for this political line to work, it must create violent conflict at home, and abroad it must expand continuously, grab continuously, and keep tensions high.



Videos Contradict Trump Administration Account of ICE Shooting in Minneapolis

An analysis of footage from three camera angles show that the vehicle appears to be turning away from a federal officer as he opened fire.

By Devon Lum, Robin Stein and Ainara Tiefenthäler

January 8, 2026



Transcript

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The Trump administration lines up in unison to defend ICE's killing of the innocent. Source:
<https://www.nytimes.com/video/us/100000010631041/minneapolis-ice-shooting-video.html>

The White House weighs how to acquire Greenland

Leaders in Greenland and Denmark are in shock. Is the president serious?

 Share



PHOTOGRAPH: AP

Jan 5th 2026 (updated Jan 6th 2026) | WASHINGTON, DC | 6 min read

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One of the territories Trump claims he wants to annex: Greenland. Other territories to annex or control include Canada, the Panama Canal, Gaza, etc. Source: <https://www.economist.com/the-americas/2026/01/05/the-white-house-weighs-how-to-acquire-greenland>

For such a regime, sitting down to discuss how to reorganize the global capitalist system and achieve a new "peaceful alliance" would mean political death. Even if it compromises temporarily, it must create confrontation elsewhere to win back the political points it lost.

Trump 'losing' trade war with China going in to Xi meeting, Senate Democrats say in report

PUBLISHED WED, OCT 29 2025-11:56 AM EDT | UPDATED WED, OCT 29 2025-8:26 PM EDT



Lori Ann LaRocco
@LORIANNLAROCO

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KEY POINTS

- President Donald Trump is "losing a self-inflicted trade war" with China ahead of his meeting with Chinese President Xi Jinping in South Korea, Senate Democrats said in a new report on the effects of Trump's tariff policy.
- "Trump's trade wars have imposed significant costs" on U.S. consumers and businesses, "sold out American farmers," and have "strengthened China's hand while weakening America's leverage," the report says.
- Sen. Elizabeth Warren of Massachusetts, the ranking Democrat on the Senate Committee on Banking, Housing, and Urban Affairs, said Trump is "putting America's long-term prosperity and security at risk."

TRENDING NOW



If it loses the trade war with China, it must win back elsewhere. Source: <https://www.cnbc.com/2025/10/29/trump-trade-china-warren-democrats-inflation-xi.html>

If American democratic forces cannot defeat the fascism of the Trump clique, the US will keep walking down the road of war. Trump, who had been keen on reducing the fiscal deficit, now proposes raising military spending to \$1.5 trillion next year — a spending increase that the so-called new tariff revenue (about \$200 billion) cannot cover. Fascist regimes in industrial countries necessarily launch wars; without external expansion they cannot survive. To wage war, who cares about the fiscal deficit?

United States Customs and Border Protection (CBP) has amassed more than \$200 billion in tariff revenue throughout 2025, the agency reported Monday.

That formidable figure includes Trump's newest "reciprocal" tariffs and punitive duties on nations across the globe—not the Section 301 tariffs levied on China during his first term in office.

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Source: <https://finance.yahoo.com/news/trade-court-denies-corporations-request-135101506.html>

(2) The Contest for Hegemony

In the current global capitalist order there is one and only one hegemon: the United States. In the Cold War period, when the US confronted the Soviet Union, the USSR led the socialist world-system and the US led the capitalist world-system. To prevent their own reddening, the capitalist countries of Latin America and Europe ceded part of their sovereignty, accepting American leadership and assistance to maintain the capitalist order of rule. The newly independent colonial countries were split: some leaned toward the socialist camp, others toward the American camp. This wavering between two world-systems — and two political lines — produced in many countries such horrors as the anti-communist massacre of Suharto in Indonesia and the slaughter of the left after Pinochet's right-wing coup in Chile. America's hegemonic position in this economic system can be reduced to three aspects: military hegemony, economic hegemony (industry, trade, and investment), and dollar hegemony.

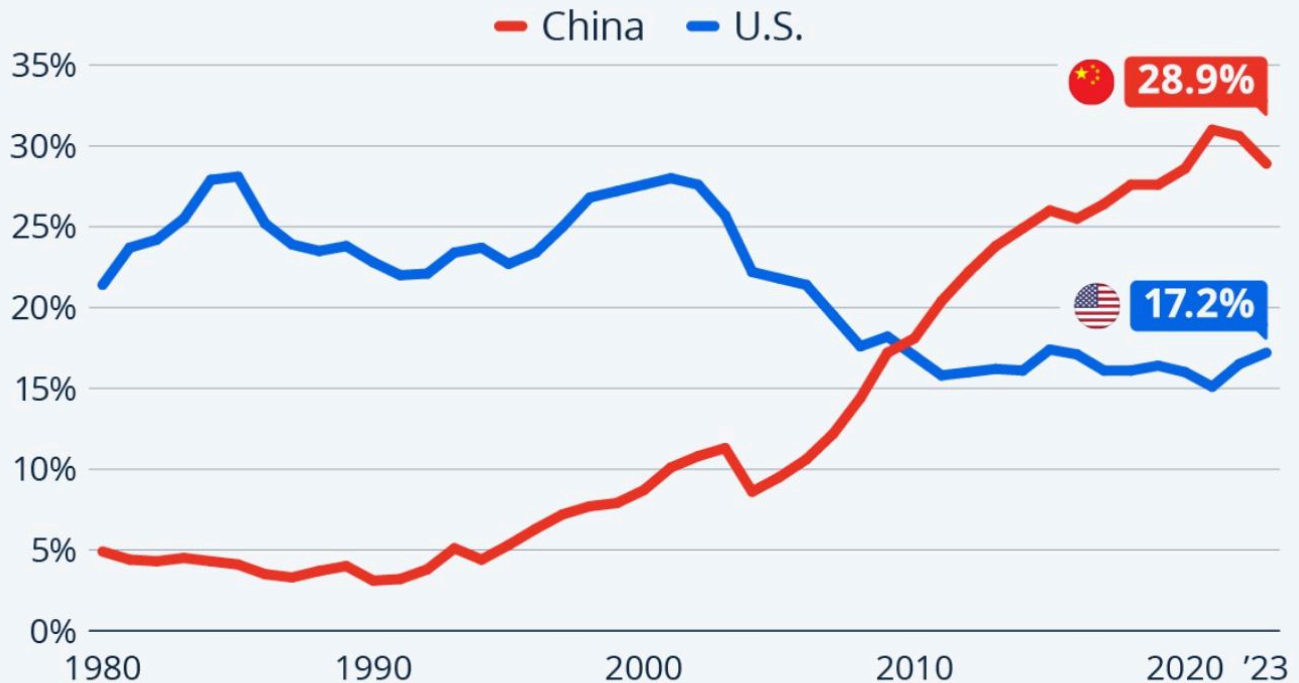
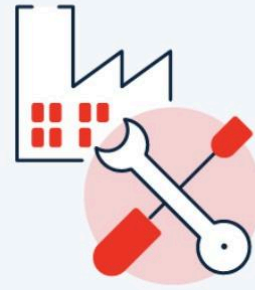
This new imperial order can be traced with great precision to the period of and immediately after the Second World War. The US established its position as military superpower by dropping atomic bombs on Hiroshima and Nagasaki, and established its economic hegemony through the Bretton Woods system, the International Monetary Fund, the World Bank, and, somewhat later, the General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade. The ostensible purpose of these agreements and organizations was to stabilize the world economy, to make it more rational by facilitating the free convertibility of world currencies into the dollar, and to establish a framework for economic reconstruction and development. But these goals could be achieved only under very specific conditions. The ultimate purpose was to open other regional economies — and their resources, labor, and markets — to Western, especially American, capital. — Ellen Wood, *Empire of Capital* (original English edition 2003)

At present, all three of America's hegemonies face serious challenges.

Though by current-dollar GDP the US remains the world's largest economy, China has overtaken it in manufacturing output, the foundation of national economic capacity.

Made in China vs. Made in America

China's and the United States' share of global manufacturing output*



* Output measured on a value-added basis in current U.S. dollars.
Prior to 2004, Chinese data includes mining and utilities.

Source: United Nations Statistics Division



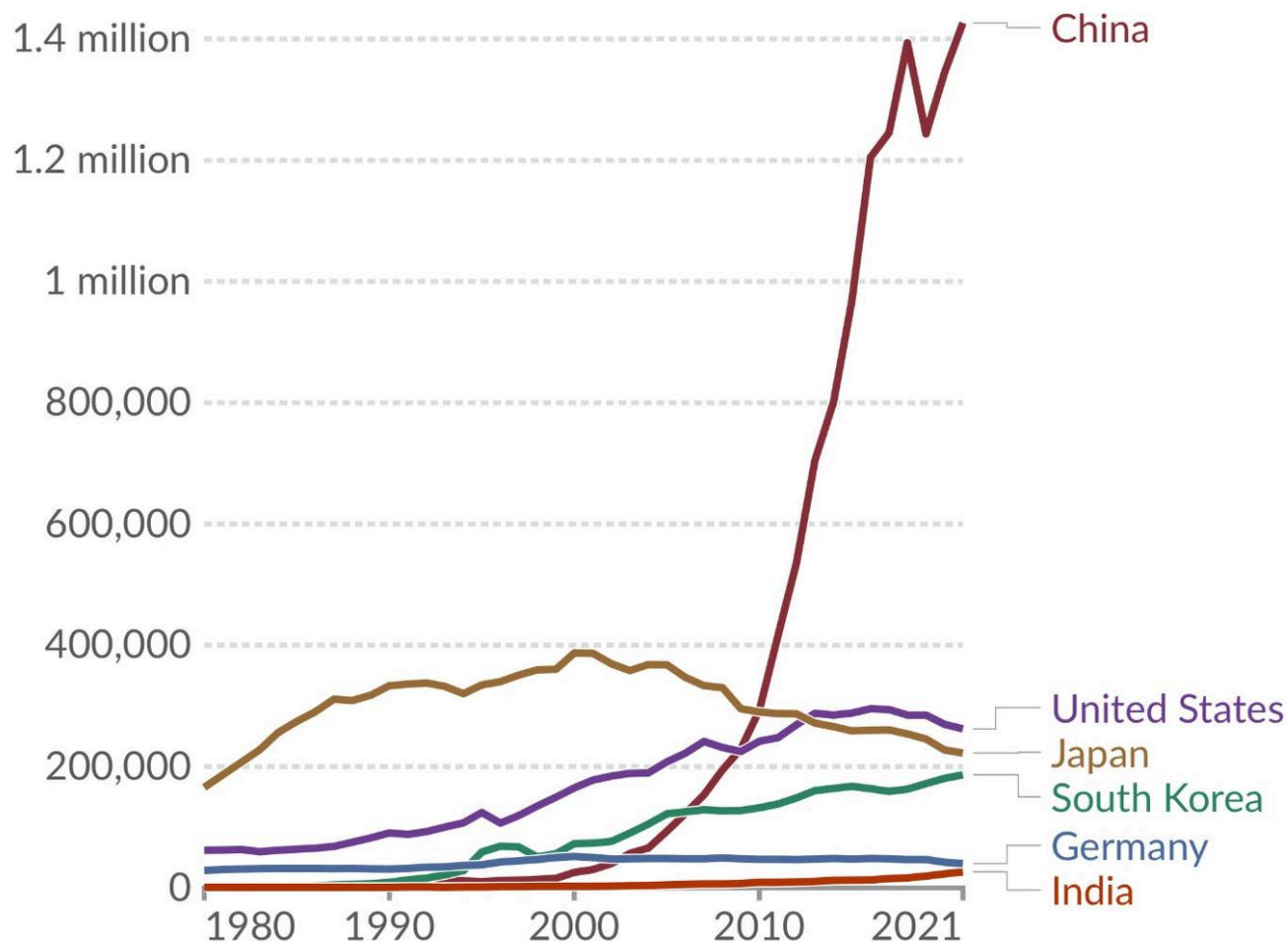
statista 知乎@最最遥远的路

Source: <https://www.statista.com/chart/20859/chinese-and-us-share-of-global-manufacturing-output/>

Innovation, the foundation of high-end industrial capability, is inevitably reflected in patent applications, and here too America has fallen behind China. Even in scientific research (the Nature Index), America has fallen behind China.

Annual patent applications

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Data source: WIPO via World Bank (2024)

Note: Each country's data includes patent applications for which the first-named applicant is a country resident.

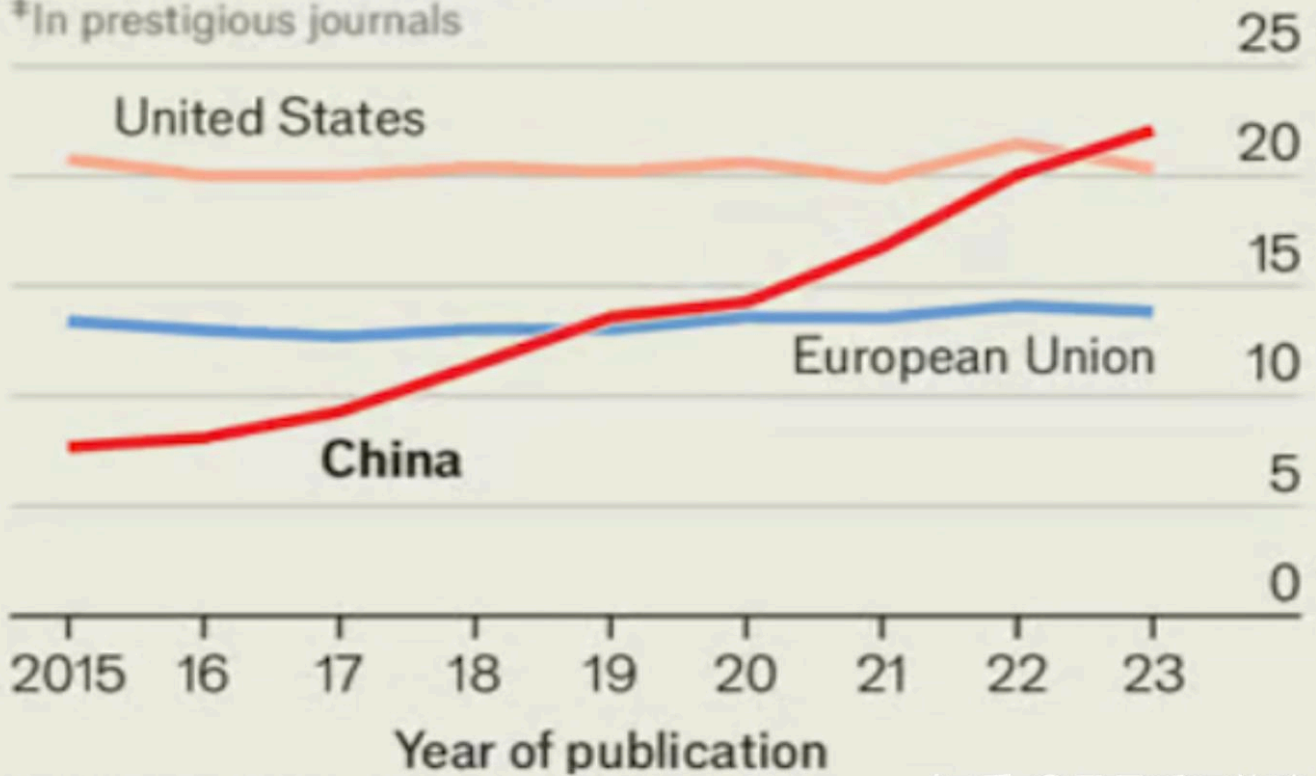
OurWorldinData.org/research-and-development | CC BY

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Patent applications

Nature Index, contributions to papers published[‡], '000

[‡]In prestigious journals



Sources: *Nature*; Clarivate, Web of Science; *The Economist*

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Nature Index

Losing industrial hegemony inevitably means losing trade hegemony, so America is no longer the largest trading partner of most countries.

Trade Timelapse: USA vs. China

Each Country's Biggest Trading Partner by Year (1980 vs. 2018)



Source: <https://howmuch.net/articles/trade-timelapse-usa-china>

America has already lost its economic hegemony. As for military and financial hegemony, though it has not yet lost its position, its advantage is no longer great, and the foundations of its hegemony are much weakened.

On military hegemony, the relevant data sources are sensitive and may be inaccurate, so we will not dwell on them. We need only mention that China was first to develop sixth-generation fighters, hypersonic missiles, and reliably operating electromagnetic catapults, to show that America no longer has an advantage in advanced military technology; its military hegemony is now propped up by a huge nuclear arsenal (including submarine launch platforms) and the existing stock of nuclear-powered aircraft carriers.

China's updated sixth-generation fighter jets put US on notice for air supremacy

Reading Time: 3 minutes

Why you can trust SCMP 



Amber Wang in Beijing

Published: 10:00pm, 2 Nov 2025 | Updated: 9:06am, 3 Nov 2025

Notable changes have been observed in both of China's sixth-generation fighter programmes, with updated prototypes seen flying just 10 months after their first public appearance, indicating rapid progress as the country vies with the US for air supremacy.

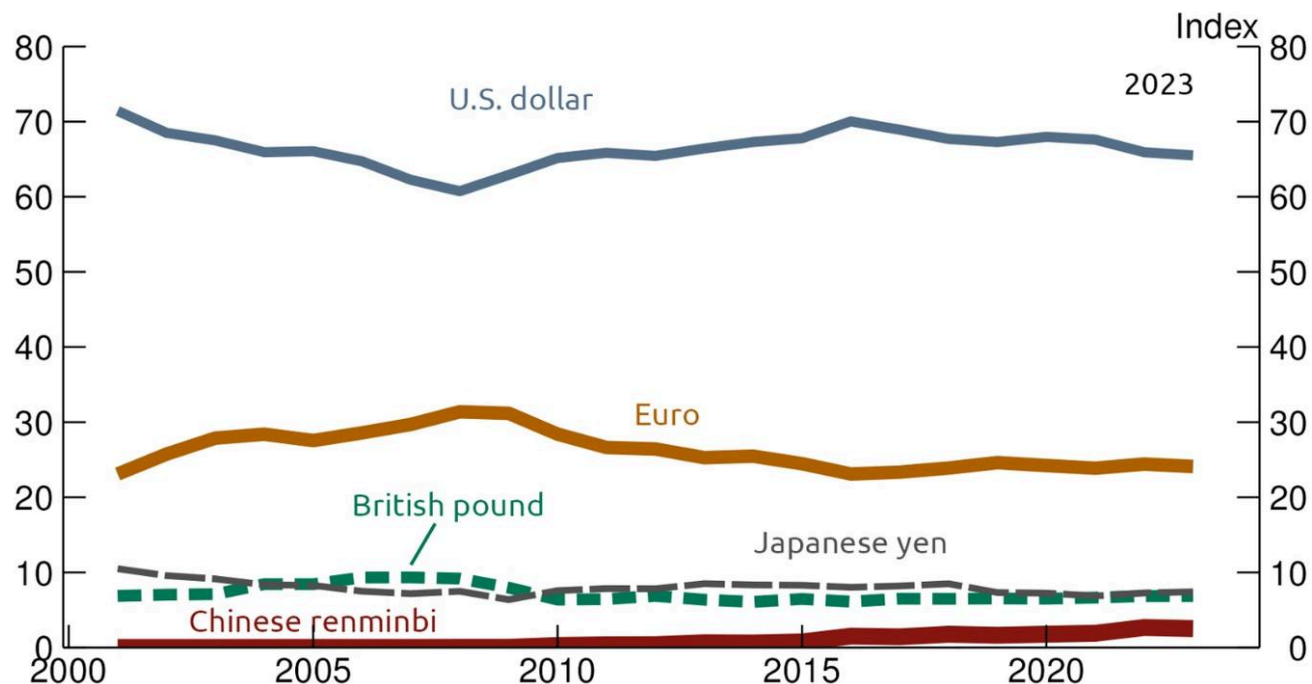
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Foreign media report the first flight of China's sixth-generation fighter. Source:

<https://www.scmp.com/news/china/military/article/3331234/chinas-updated-6th-generation-fighter-jets-put-us-notice-air-supremacy>

America's most secure position today is financial hegemony. The dollar still leads far ahead in all major indicators: foreign-exchange reserves, foreign-exchange market turnover, etc.

Figure 1. Index of international currency usage



Note: Index is a weighted average of each currency's share of globally disclosed FX reserves (25 percent weight), FX transaction volume (25 percent), foreign currency debt issuance (25 percent), foreign currency and international banking claims (12.5 percent), and foreign currency and international banking liabilities (12.5 percent).

Source: IMF COFER; BIS Triennial Central Bank Survey of FX and OTC Derivatives Market; Refinitiv; BIS locational banking statistics; Board staff calculations.

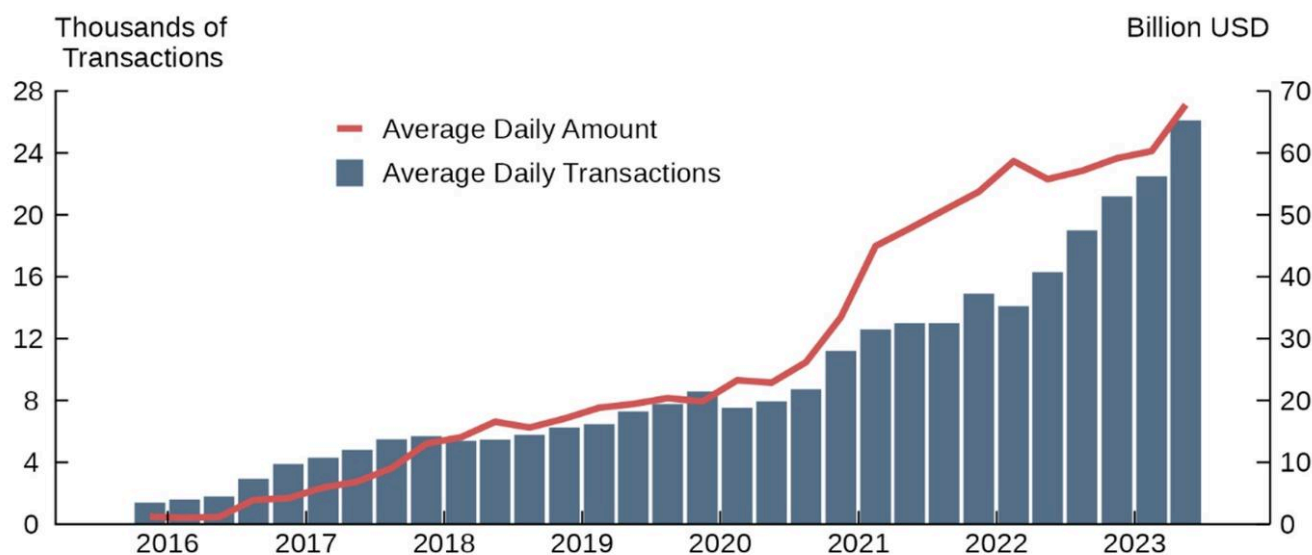
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Source: <https://www.federalreserve.gov/econres/notes/feds-notes/internationalization-of-the-chinese-renminbi-progress-and-outlook-20240830.html>

Since China has already achieved economic hegemony and become the largest trading nation, even without full convertibility of the renminbi, its internationalization momentum remains strong.

Figure 3. Number and value of cross-border transactions processed by CIPS



Source: People's Bank of China.

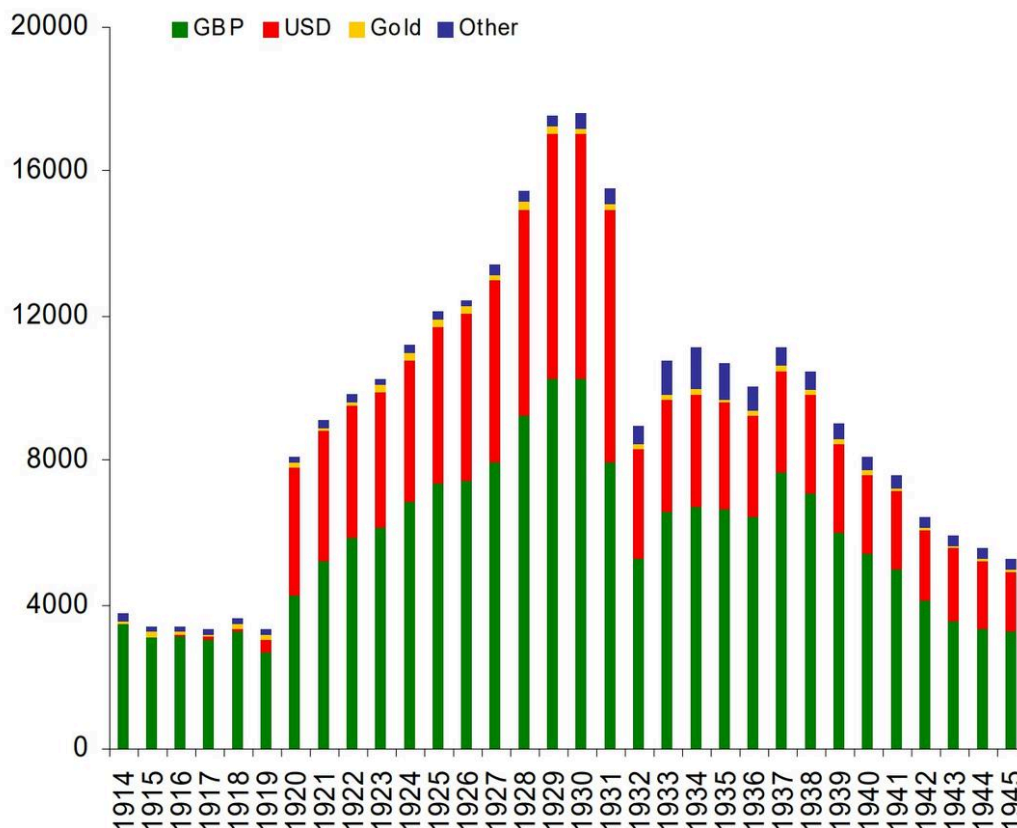
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Source: <https://www.federalreserve.gov/econres/notes/feds-notes/internationalization-of-the-chinese-renminbi-progress-and-outlook-20240830.html>

However, the scenario some imagine — America losing dollar hegemony in the short term — is, by the experience of the last world currency change, unlikely. The US replaced Britain as the largest economy in 1894, yet until World War I the dollar's status was far below sterling's; the dollar is generally considered to have fully replaced sterling only after World War II, though some scholars hold that the dollar overtook sterling as the world's first currency in 1929. But on either view, the dollar's replacement of sterling came at least 30 years after America became the world's largest economy. China's total economy has not yet surpassed America's; by PPP, China's economy surpassed America's in 2014. That means the renminbi's replacement of the dollar's international status will come around 2045 or later. So, by historical experience — unless a world war breaks out and America loses — dollar hegemony will most likely last at least another 20 years.

Figure 2: Global foreign public debt
(Currency breakdown in USD million; at current exchange rates)



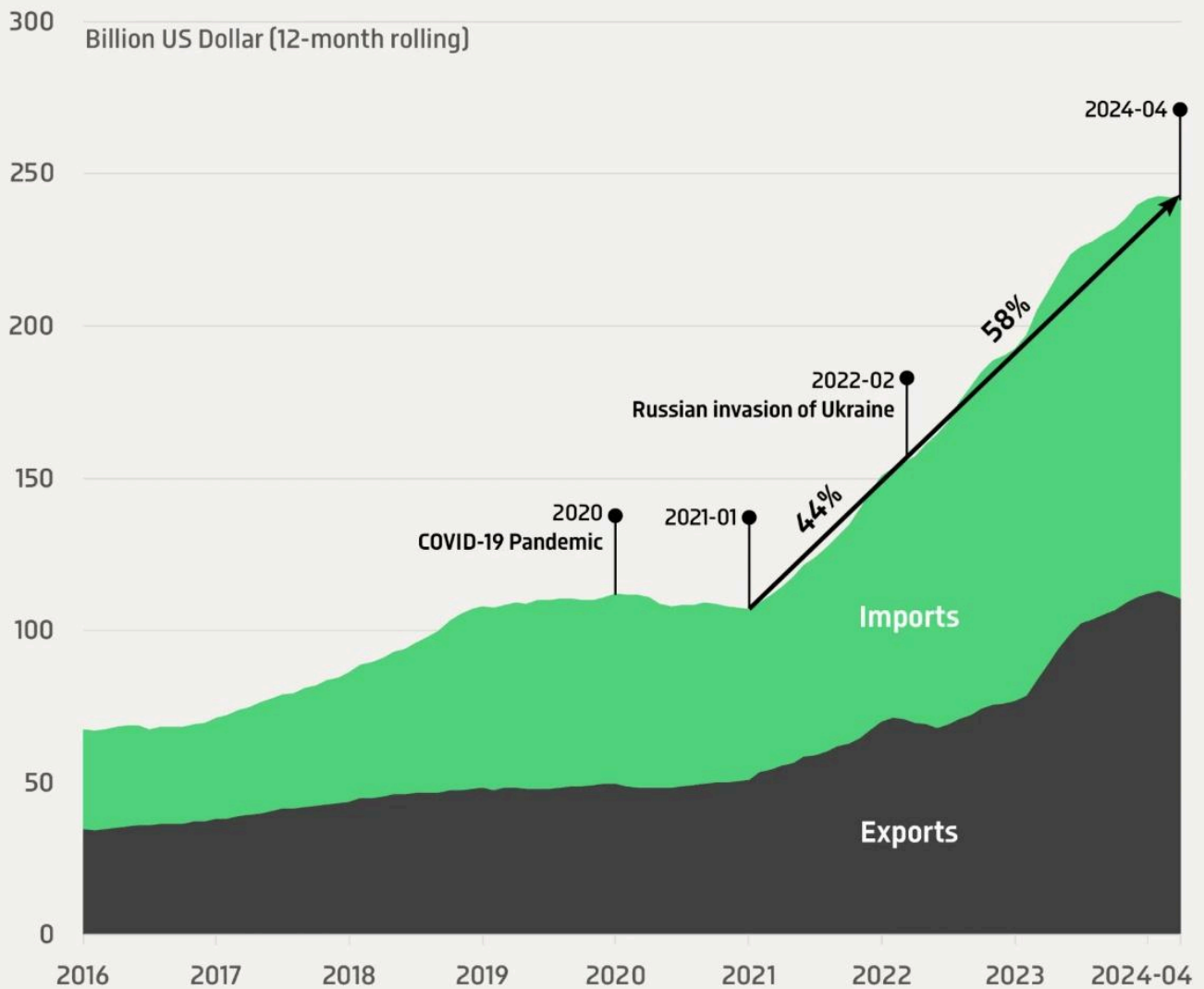
Notes: Authors' own estimates based on United Nations (1948) as well as the *GFD* and *Measuring Worth* databases on exchange rates. The figure plots over time the global stock of foreign public debt, in USD million and at current exchange rates, calculated with our full sample of 33 countries, and broken down into selected currencies.

Source: <https://www.ecb.europa.eu/pub/pdf/scpwps/ecbwp1433.pdf>

America, having lost industrial hegemony, cannot — even with stable financial hegemony — bring Russia, with its much smaller economy, to its knees by unprecedented financial sanctions. The reason is simple: China withstood American pressure and insisted on maintaining trade with Russia. Even without supplying any weapons, normal trade alone has made it impossible for the whole of Europe and America to defeat Russia.

China Trade with Russia More than Doubled in Last Three Years

China's trade with Russia surged before the Ukraine conflict. From January 2021 to April 2024, overall trade increased by 127%, with exports up by 117% and imports by 136% (12-month rolling average).



Sources: Customs of China

Research and visualization by Ehsan Soltani

www.econovis.net



China–Russia trade has surged since 2022

Having lost economic hegemony, and watching financial hegemony lose its expected effect, America can only use its military and financial hegemony to weaken the other side's industrial hegemony. This too is what Lenin identified as the usual means of imperialist rivalry.

An important feature of imperialism is the competition of several great powers for hegemony — that is, for territory, with the aim not so much of directly acquiring it as of weakening the adversary and undermining its hegemony... "World hegemony" is the content of imperialist politics, and the

continuation of imperialist politics is imperialist war. — Lenin, Imperialism, the Highest Stage of Capitalism

Relying on dollar hegemony, America can sustain over a trillion dollars of annual trade deficit. Relying on the trade deficit, it can launch "tariff wars," forcing firms of all countries to invest and build plants in America, lowering tariffs on some industrial countries while keeping high tariffs on others, thus pushing global industry (including Chinese firms) to "de-risk" and "diversify" away from the industrial hegemon.

U.S. Trade Deficit Hits Record High Ahead of Tariff Impact

U.S. net exports of goods and services
(in chained 2017 dollars)*

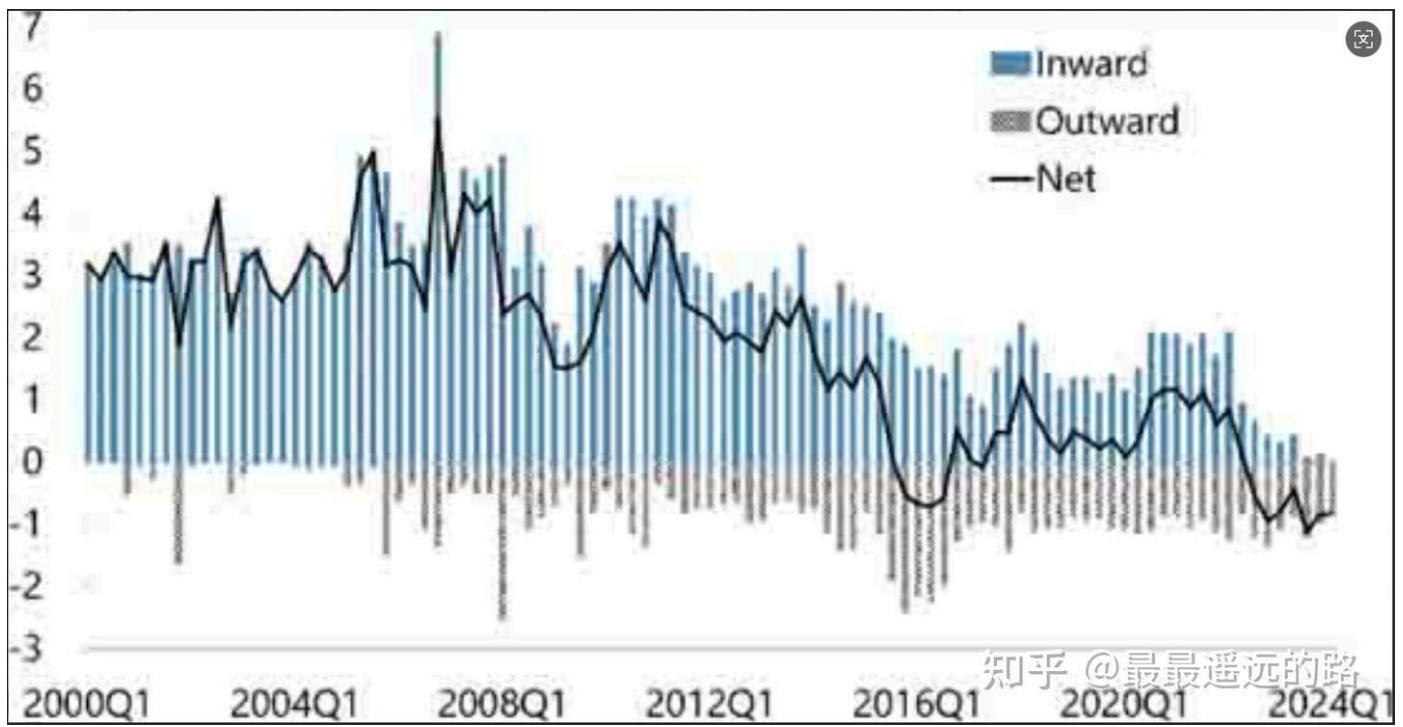


* Seasonally adjusted annual rates

Source: U.S. Bureau of Economic Analysis



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FDI trends. Source: <https://www.elibrary.imf.org/view/journals/002/2024/276/article-A004-en.xml>

Of course, after failing in the trade war, America has turned back to military means — violence and coercion — to weaken the adversary's industrial hegemony. America's use of force in the Middle East (Iran, Qatar) and Latin America (Venezuela) all serves this purpose.

U.S. gains in AI race as Gulf nations ditch China for chips

Washington has all but locked Beijing out of the Middle East's trillion-dollar artificial intelligence ambitions.



Chip Somodevilla/Getty Images

By **INDRANIL GHOSH**

21 NOVEMBER 2025

翻译成中文 (简体字)



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By supporting Israel's strikes on Iran, the Middle East's largest opposition force, it intimidates the whole region. Under American and Israeli military-hegemonic pressure, Middle Eastern countries give up Chinese chips, in effect slowing China's high-tech development as Washington demands. Source: <https://restofworld.org/2025/mideast-us-chip-deal-and-china/>

Likewise, America is using its still-held financial hegemony — through fiscal deficits (issuing treasury debt) — to rapidly expand its military. According to one American think tank's estimate, the Trump administration will add a total of \$5 trillion in military budgets by 2035. If readers don't grasp how huge \$5 trillion is, calculate how many F-35s or Ford-class carriers it buys (an F-35 costs about \$100 million; even at the disaster-level \$120 billion per carrier reported by US media, it builds 40). America's current defense industrial capacity is insufficient, and it is drawing on allies' industry (e.g., Korean shipbuilders) to support its military expansion. Even considering America's high production costs, the colossal military outlay can still build a huge modern military. Clearly, the Trump clique intends to use this "dream army" to wage the hegemonic war in the 2030s.

defense budget plan could widen deficits

By Reuters

January 9, 2026 6:01 AM GMT+8 · Updated January 9, 2026



U.S. President Donald Trump speaks during a Mexican Border Defense Medal presentation in the Oval Office at the White House in Washington, D.C., U.S., December 15, 2025. REUTERS/Evelyn Hockstein [Purchase Licensing Rights](#)

NEW YORK, Jan 8 (Reuters) - U.S. President Donald Trump's proposed increase in defense spending for 2027 is unlikely to be offset by savings or revenues and would have a negative impact on already large U.S. fiscal deficits, said an analyst at Moody's Ratings.

Trump said on Wednesday the 2027 U.S. military budget should be \$1.5 trillion, significantly higher than the \$901 billion approved by Congress for 2026. Any such increase in the military budget would require congressional authorization. The Committee for a Responsible Federal Budget, a nonpartisan think tank, estimated the proposal would cost \$5 trillion through 2035, while adding \$5.8 trillion to the U.S. debt with interest.

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Source: <https://www.reuters.com/world/us/trump-says-us-military-budget-2027-should-be-15-trillion-2026-01-07/>

The Navy's Ford-Class \$120 Billion Aircraft Carrier Nightmare Has Just Begun



By [Reuben Johnson](#) Published March 8, 2025



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Source: <https://www.19fortyfive.com/2025/03/the-navys-ford-class-120-billion-aircraft-carrier-nightmare-has-just-begun/>

When American imperialism tramples the peoples of Palestine and Venezuela, people are shocked, feeling this should not happen. But as long as imperialism exists, these atrocities — bullying small and medium countries for the sake of hegemony — will never completely disappear.

The imperialists of Britain and Germany, for "their own" cause — that is, for the seizure of world hegemony — have not hesitated to utterly destroy and strangle a whole host of countries, from Belgium and Serbia to Palestine and Mesopotamia. Then are socialists, for "their own" cause — to free the working people of the whole world from the yoke of capital, to win universal and lasting peace — to look on and wait because no path without sacrifice can be found? — Lenin, Letter to American Workers (August 20, 1918)

III. Factors That Lower the Risk of War

(1) Trade Dependence

Any war's outbreak must reckon with the interruption of trade. If one depends on foreign goods — especially from the enemy — and especially for the military industry, then once war begins, one may have to sue for peace because factories stop. And imperialist countries exist within the capitalist world market; none is self-sufficient. By this argument, world wars should never break out. Indeed, because the capitalist world-system experienced a wave of globalization from the mid-nineteenth to the early twentieth century and trade developed unprecedentedly, many people before World War I thought exactly this. But why did war still come?

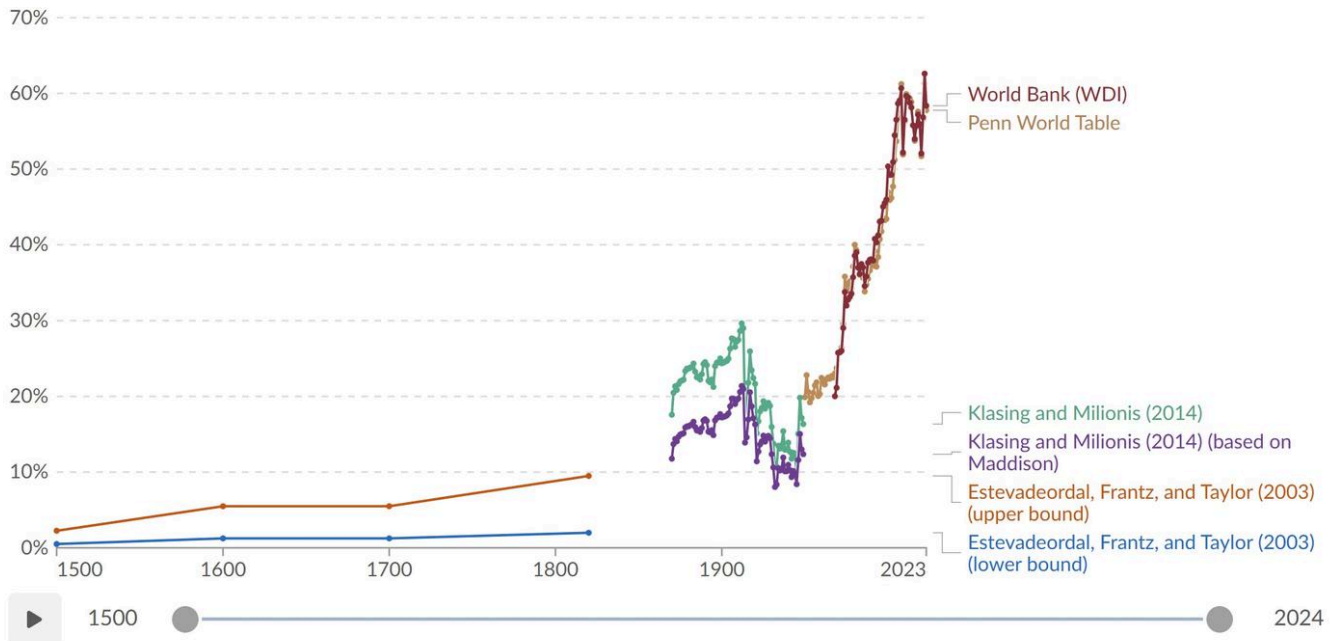
Globalization over five centuries, World

Shown is the "trade openness index". This index is defined as the sum of world exports and imports, divided by world GDP. Each series corresponds to a different source.

Our World
in Data

Table

Chart



Data source: Klasing and Milionis (2014) and other sources - [Learn more about this data](#)

OurWorldinData.org/trade-and-globalization | CC BY

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Total trade as a share of world GDP. The pre-WWI trade peak was not surpassed until the 1970s. Source: <https://ourworldindata.org/trade-and-globalization>

Because, besides stockpiling before the war, allies could solve each other's material supply problems, trade with neutrals would not be interrupted, and resources could be obtained from occupied territories by "sustaining war through war." Even trade between belligerents might not be fully cut off — as during the Russia–Ukraine war, gas trade continued.

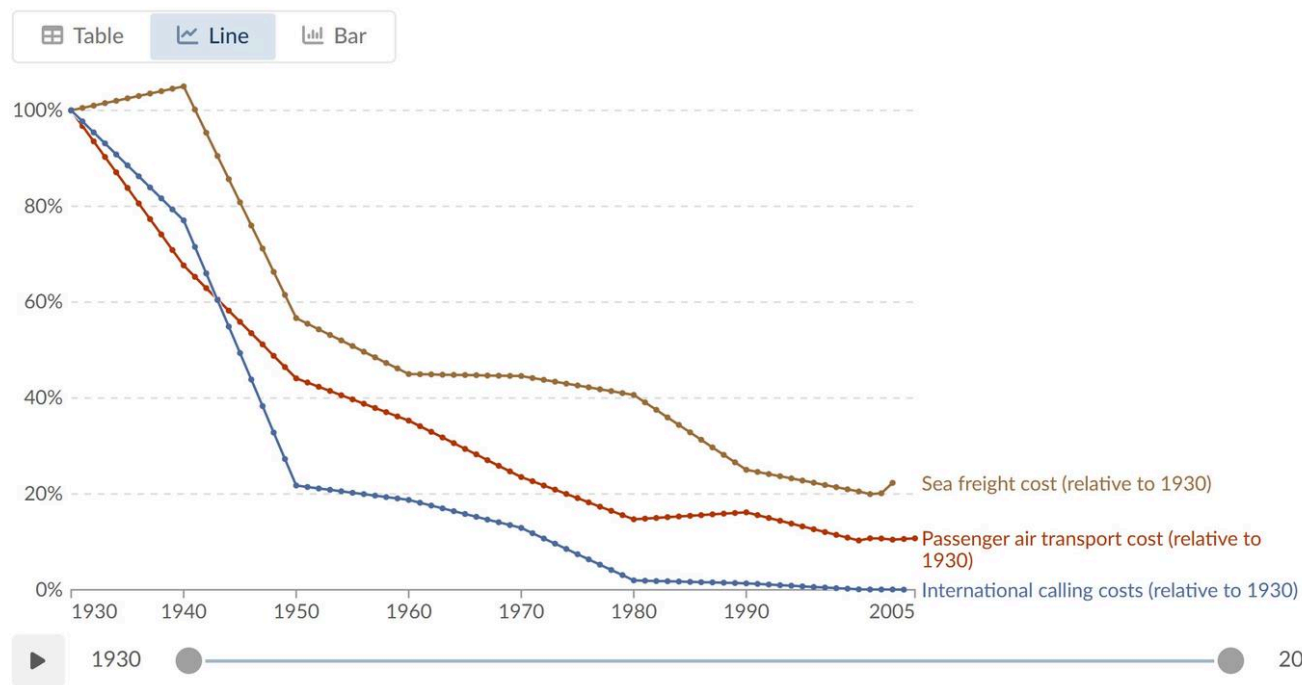
In 1913, 52.2 percent of Germany's merchandise imports were raw materials such as copper ore and semi-finished goods such as copper, 38.2 percent foodstuffs, and the rest manufactured goods. Prewar exports were mainly manufactures (63.9 percent), meaning imports of raw materials and semi-finished goods often exceeded domestic basic needs. The top five imported categories of raw materials and semi-finished goods were textile fibers and yarns (1.913 billion marks, 34 percent of all raw-material and semi-finished imports), nonferrous metals and their ores (769 million marks), raw hides (667 million), timber (347 million), and iron ore (227 million). Other raw materials essential to the war economy included coal (205 million), mineral oil products (174 million), Chilean saltpeter (172 million), and rubber (126 million). Except for iron ore, coal, and timber, all these raw materials were mainly imported from overseas. Also important to the war effort were raw materials whose prewar imports were not high but on which Germany heavily depended on imports, often from later enemies and often from overseas: tanning agents for the leather industry (47 million marks) and pyrite (25

million marks), mainly from Spain, used to produce sulfuric acid, the basis of the chemical and explosives industries. Germany imported a wide variety of raw materials or products during the war. For rubber, besides stockpiles obtained in occupied territories (especially in 1914), blockade runners played a vital role, accounting for over two-thirds of wartime imports. Occupied territories' stockpiles also played a crucial role in imports of textile fibers and yarns. Occupied territories were an important source of iron ore (France), scrap iron, and some nonferrous metals — ores, scrap, and metal, plus chrome and copper ore from Serbia. In other cases, neutral countries played an important role in supplying Germany with key raw materials, especially nickel, tin, iron ore, and aluminum. Austria-Hungary was an important supplier of key raw materials, especially bauxite for aluminum production and steel alloys such as vanadium, tungsten, and molybdenum. Shortly after the war began, Austria-Hungary began mining bauxite to replace French bauxite, making Germany's aluminum industry possible. Mineral oil was imported from Romania and Austria-Hungary. — Paper (machine-translated, for reference): Jonas Scherner, "Germany, Blockade and Strategic Raw Materials in the Era of the Two World Wars"

Still, as the paper shows, what Germany needed was mainly primary products — minerals and farm produce; manufactured goods were a small share, and industrial intermediates like components even smaller. Since the categories were few and the technology not advanced, they could be replaced quickly by opening new mines in time. But a major change after the 1970s — the container revolution and the development of information technology — gave birth to cross-national intra-product division of labor, driving intermediate goods' share of global trade up rapidly.

The decline of transport and communication costs relative to 1930

Sea freight corresponds to average international freight charges per tonne. Passenger air transport corresponds to average airline revenue per passenger-mile until 2000 spliced to US import air passenger fares afterwards. International calls correspond to cost of a three-minute call from New York to London.



Data source: Transaction Costs - OECD Economic Outlook (2007) - [Learn more about this data](#)
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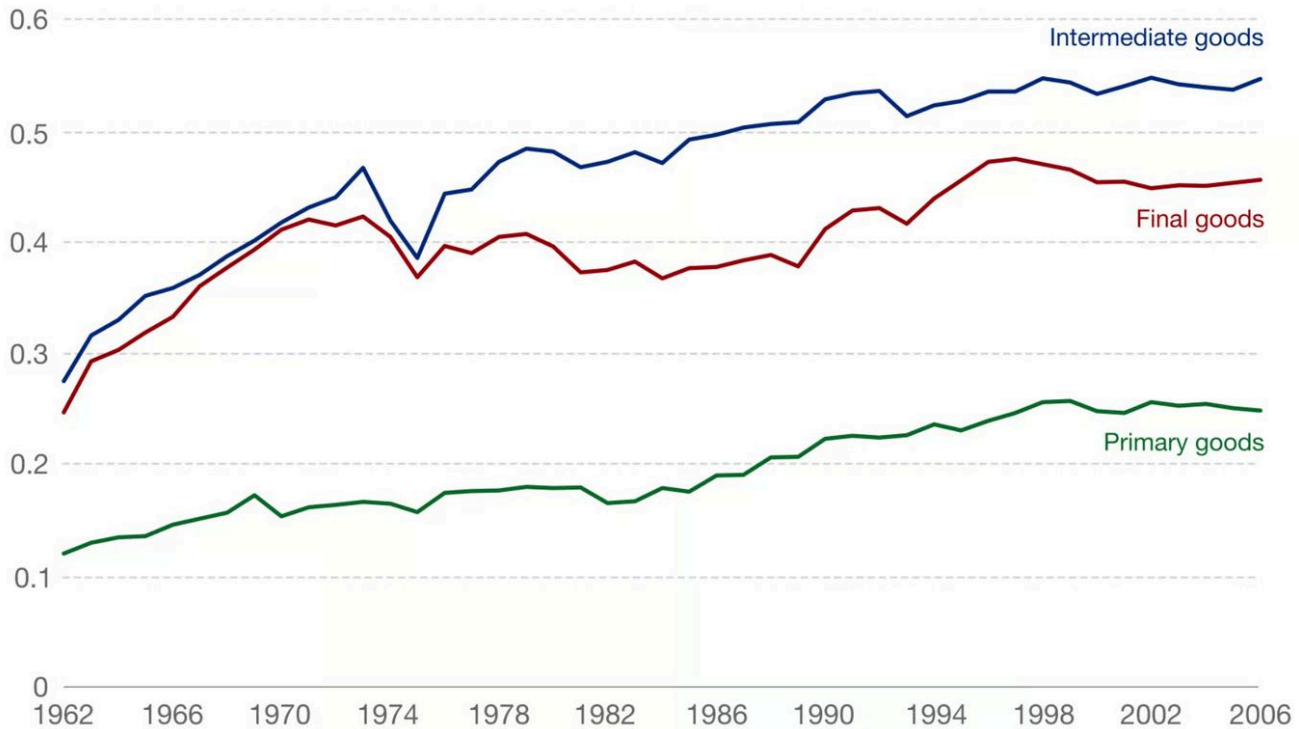
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The decline in transport and communication costs. Source: <https://ourworldindata.org/trade-and-globalization>

Share of intra-industry trade by type of goods

Share of intra-industry trade corresponds to the exchange of broadly similar goods and services. Here it is measured through the Grubel-Lloyd Index, by 3-digit product group.

Our World
in Data



Source: Figure 6.1 in UN World Development Report (2009).

This is a visualization from OurWorldinData.org, where you find data and research on how the world is changing. Licensed under CC-BY-SA by the authors Esteban Ortiz-Ospina and Diana Beltekian

Share of intraindustry trade by type of goods – Figure 6.1 in UN World Development Report (2009)

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Trade by product category. Intermediate goods have for years been over 50 percent of trade, approaching 60 percent. Source: <https://ourworldindata.org/trade-and-globalization>

The global division of labor across products, producing a high share of intermediate-goods trade, does hinder the outbreak of war. The most typical example is the United States. The American defense industry is deeply dependent on the Chinese supply chain, especially rare earths: 41 percent of US weapons systems depend on Chinese semiconductors, and 91 percent of US Navy supply chains depend on Chinese rare earths.

Articles Exclusive Policy

The US and China: Deep dependency amid increasing strategic competition

David Saw

16. October 2025

Looking back at the heights of US strategic dominance in the 1990s, by 2025 the sun looks to have well and truly set on the unipolar international system. [US ANG/MSgt Luke Olson]



Today around 41% of US weapons and defence infrastructure is reliant on Chinese semiconductors, while 91% of Navy weapons incorporate critical minerals whose supply is reliant on Chinese industry. As America pivots to the Pacific, it faces the stark reality that its military superiority increasingly depends on China – the very country it is preparing to potentially confront.

In the early 1990s, the US saw its strategic situation transformed; the Warsaw Pact had imploded and the Soviet Union, the primary strategic rival of the US, had collapsed. The US was the dominant power globally, having the largest economy and demonstrating its superior military power as a US-led coalition defeated Iraq in Operation Desert Storm between January and February 1991. In the taxonomy of international relations, the bipolarity of the Cold War era (1945–1990) had been replaced by unipolar

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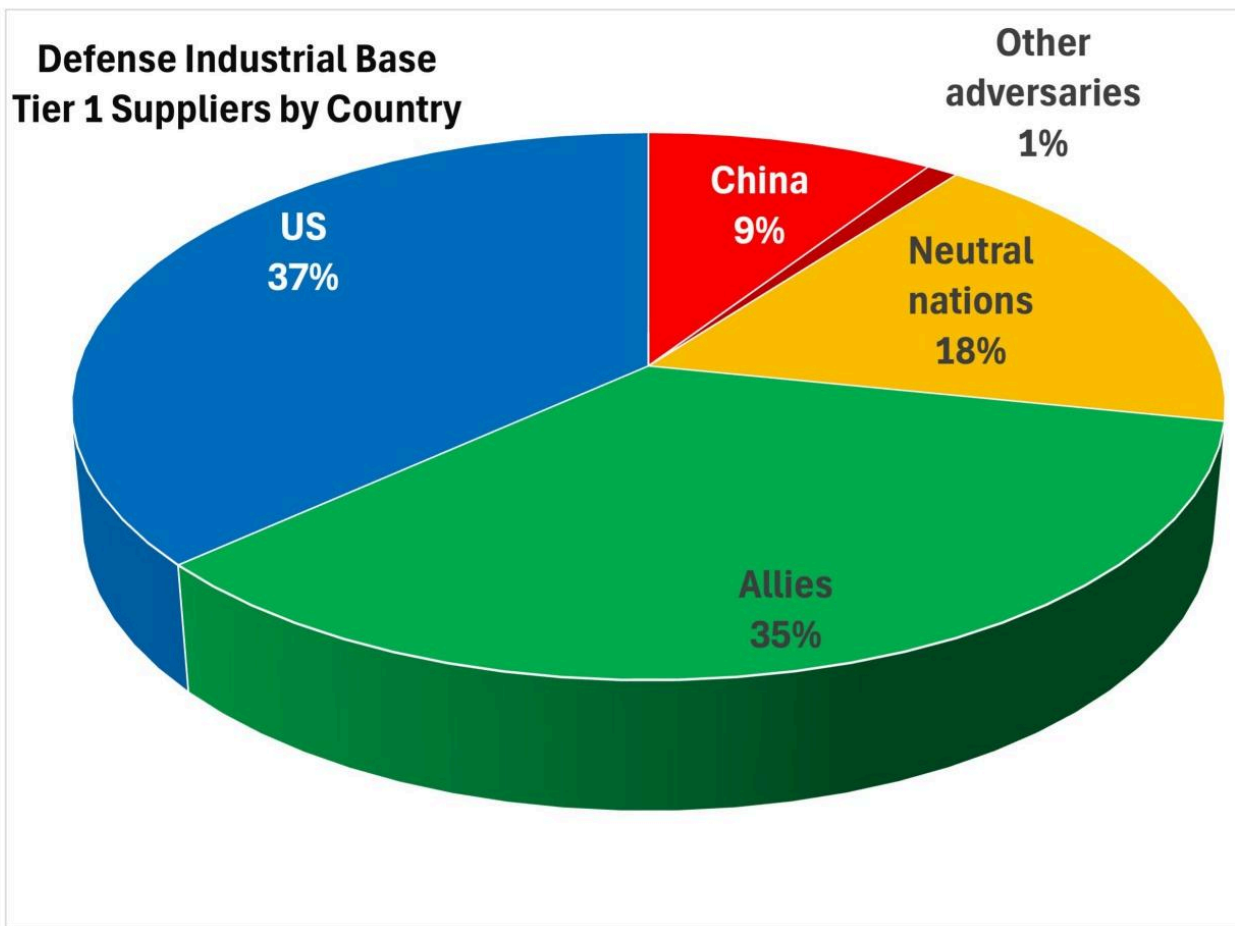
Evolving border threats
need smarter solutions
Discover the next gen
of border intelligence

See it in action

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Source: <https://euro-sd.com/2025/10/articles/exclusive/47240/the-us-and-china-deep-dependency-amid-increasing-strategic-competition/>

After America's efforts to cut the Chinese supply chain, nearly 10 percent of weapons production still depends on Chinese Tier-1 suppliers — firms that sell components or finished products directly to American defense contractors. This shows the extent of the US supply chain's dependence on China. Rare earths especially: one F-35 requires more than 400 kilograms of rare earth materials (including neodymium, samarium, dysprosium, terbium, and yttrium). Without China's rare earths, the entire American defense industry would grind to a halt and be unable to fight a war. This is why China's rare-earth card works so well.



Chinese firms make up over 9% of the major subcontractors ("Tier 1 Suppliers") on Defense Department contracts. (Breaking Defense analysis of Govini data)

Source: Nearly one in 10 "Tier 1" subcontractors to defense primes are Chinese firms: Report.

<https://breakingdefense.com/2025/06/nearly-one-in-10-tier-1-subcontractors-to-defense-primes-are-chinese-firms-report/>

Moreover, the rare-earth industry chain is long, with many links upstream, midstream, and downstream; refining is the key, not merely mining. Most institutions estimate 10–15 years to rebuild; some optimistically say 6–7.

Both US government bodies and research institutions generally agree the rebuilding cycle is long. CSIS holds that the dominance of the global rare-earth supply structure will not change hands in the short term. The US Department of Energy estimates rebuilding a full rare-earth supply chain would take 10 years and \$300 billion. RAND says the American rare-earth industry will still face high costs and long operating cycles. Overseas projects cannot be done overnight: Stimson Center experts say the US government's goals for overseas rare-earth development cooperation are hard to achieve — the Myanmar cooperation plan lacks both the technology and logistics for commercial rare-earth output, and even mining equipment and other supplies need Chinese support. The Council on Foreign Relations is also pessimistic about future mineral projects in Greenland; the special geography and climate make commercial mining a matter of "years, decades, or even longer." Source: Institute of

At present, however, insiders in the American rare-earth industry say the problem is neither lack of funds nor lack of market, but that after a long industrial gap, experienced and skilled workers and engineers are hard to find outside China. Some in the American strategic community therefore believe the rare-earth problem cannot be solved by rebuilding the whole chain, but by purchasing on the market and building strategic reserves.

造成美国上述能力不足的深层原因在于,其稀土技术体系的持续性衰退。长期以来,受产业外迁、政策支持不足与学科边缘化等多重因素影响,美国稀土相关专业的人才培养体系几近瓦解,导致其本土稀土产业重建过程中出现政策导向明确但人才供给严重不足的结构性难题。稀土分离提纯、金属冶炼与永磁材料制备等关键环节的技术主要涉及经验性知识与隐性工艺,无法完全通过教材与标准化程序传授,技能掌握与工艺传承需经过长期工程实践与现场调试才能完成。^② 然而,自 20 世纪 90 年代美国稀土产业整体性收缩以来,大批具备工艺实践经验的资深工程师陆续退出岗位,而新生代人才因缺乏产业平台无法在实践中积累专业能力、获得技术传承。^③ 在芒廷帕斯矿重启过程中,芒廷山口材料公司曾多次公开表示,其在招募具备大型萃取槽操作经验的工程技术人员方面面临巨大困难,不得不从海外高薪引进技术顾问来协助调试设备。^④

此外,美国高等教育体系在相关领域的人才培养也有明显不足。20 世纪,美国多所高校专门设有矿物加工、稀土化学与冶金工程等学科,但近年来,这些专业大多被并入材料科学或环境工程等大类,招生规模持续缩减,课程设置也日益与实际产业需求脱节。由于就业市场缺乏相应岗位,不少毕业生选择转向新能源、电气或金融等行业,导致人才供给与产业需求的结构性失衡进一步加剧。据统计,1982—2023 年,美国工程与技术认证委员会 (Accreditation Board for Engineering and Technology) 认证的采矿工程本科项目数量从 25 个减少至 14 个,近半数高校已取消相关专业设置;同时,相关毕业生数量大幅下滑,全美采矿工程本科毕业人数已由 2015 年的 371 人下降至 2023 年的 162 人,完全无法满足能源转型和国防工业对稀土人才的实际需求。^① 相较之下,中国通过国家工程中心、地方研究院以及中国科学院等科研机构,形成了覆盖稀土产业链全链条的高密度人才体系,培养了大量冶金、材料、化工等领域的专业技术人员,为本土稀土产业的技术积累与持续迭代提供了强有力的人才支撑。^② 技术基础薄弱与人才不足意味着,即便美国政府在资金与制度层面加大对稀土产业的支持力度,也难以帮助相关人员在短期内掌握复杂工艺流程。

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Source: Contemporary American Review, "America's rare-earth policy amid great-power strategic competition"

<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/cXTagNBeo8zbaZ5L8KjioQ>

International academia has various views on this question. Though these scholars all regard China as a potential challenger to the order, failing to perceive America's possible transformation into a breaker of the order, their basic principles are consistent and worth reference.

Some scholars hold that the supply-chain fragmentation caused by production globalization has significantly raised the difficulty of great powers overturning the international order.

On the technology dimension, the "high-sensitivity technology dependence" of semiconductors creates "asymmetric deterrence" — the US chip ban on China (e.g., the 2022 comprehensive restrictions on advanced process equipment) briefly curbs China's military technology upgrading, yet triggers "reverse innovation incentives": Huawei launches "de-Americanized" chip R&D, SMIC's 14nm yield rises to 95 percent, and by 2023 the localization rate of China's semiconductor equipment procurement exceeds 35 percent. This negative feedback loop of "technology decoupling → accelerated self-reliance" weakens the "deterrent efficacy" of long-term economic interdependence, confirming the "double-edged sword" logic of production globalization for great powers: supply-chain fragmentation both raises the cost of conquest and reduces the long-term sustainability of external sanctions. Until the last decades of the twentieth century, great powers could basically manufacture cutting-edge weapons independently. But given the high complexity of today's advanced production, no country can remain in defense-related production on the strength of its own firms alone. In the past, great powers could maintain their weapons-production capability even after supply lines were cut; today the constraining effect of supply interruption will be greatly enhanced. When the economic benefit of conquering advanced countries is low, and great powers cannot act independently in production, they find it harder to use force to overturn the basic international order. However, the security benefits of globalized production do not apply to the actions of developing countries. After all, poor countries are incapable of conquering advanced countries, so their military actions rarely trigger broad economic restrictions. — Stephen G. Brooks, Professor of Government, Dartmouth College: 1) "Is economic interdependence still a guarantee of peace?" 2) "Does this ballast stone of trade block war?"

But other scholars hold that even in wartime the belligerents will likely keep trading, so trade dependence cannot prevent war.

One of the most prominent arguments for optimism about China's rise is the theory of economic interdependence. Given the extensive trade links between China and its neighbors and the US, all these countries have strong incentives not to fight each other, because war would end trade between the belligerents and thus undermine their domestic prosperity. Other things being equal, trade can deter war. Of course, this deterrent effect exists only if trade relations between wartime enemies are severed. However, wartime trade between adversaries is possible — indeed very common in the historical record — because even during war, states have strong reasons to keep trading with the enemy. But if particular circumstances lead states to trade during wartime, trade cannot deter such military conflict. The two main scenarios in which China might become involved in war with another nuclear power: a China–US conflict arising from geopolitical rivalry; and a war between China and India over the long-

standing border dispute. In short, limited wars, all belligerents may allow substantial trade, mainly because the enemy has no time to convert trade gains into military capability. Cutting trade brings no benefit. In the second type of war: a rising China might fight wars with America's close allies, such as Japan and South Korea. If China goes to war with an American close ally, the US would likely be drawn directly into the conflict. Given the danger of nuclear escalation in such a war, it would probably be short and limited — meaning wartime trade would be allowed. Thus trade is unlikely to prevent war between China and America's close allies. On the whole, the expectation that important economic ties will help prevent conflict between a rising China and its neighbors or the US is mistaken. Moreover, the greater the economic interdependence between China and any of its potential enemies, the more likely they are to trade during wartime, eliminating trade considerations as a deterrent to military conflict. Source: Mariya Grinberg, PhD in political science, University of Chicago, "Wartime commercial policy and trade with hostile countries"

So globalization makes the industries of the world's countries interdependent; by dispersing products across many countries, it lowers the success rate of "sustaining war through war," forcing countries that want war to be very cautious. China also admonishes all parties: "Interdependence is not a risk; intertwined interests are not a threat." But this remains only a risk-lowering factor; for a political clique that must fight, this obstacle cannot stop it. By building a huge army before the war and stockpiling the materials essential to the defense industry (raw materials and components), the war machine can still be set in motion. They can also hope to gain industrial advantage through war by seizing key industrial bases or destroying the enemy's industrial capacity. As for the shortage of civilian goods, history shows that to warmongers this is not a problem that must be solved.

(2) The Resistance of Small and Medium Nation-States

In World War II, neither Germany nor Japan began by launching a world war; they developed into imperialist hegemonic wars only after their ambitions expanded step by step through annexing small and medium countries. The resistance of small and medium countries to imperialist aggression helps lower the risk of world war.

Though their national strength is far below that of the imperialist countries, once the imperialist country is mired in ground war, even long-term counterinsurgency, it is often drowned in the vast ocean of people's war. In this respect, postwar history provides glorious examples of small and medium countries resisting imperialism.

The first example is French imperialism's defeat in Algeria.

Algerian urban elites and rural groups together took the path of armed resistance in 1954. When the Algerians formally declared war, French imperial policy was already in turmoil from another major event: the loss of Indochina after the decisive defeat at Dien Bien Phu. The French government,

already embittered by defeat in Vietnam, resolved to make no further concessions, responding quickly and without reservation by sending troops to "defend" Algeria against the nationalist threat. The armed uprising quickly escalated and spread, gradually affecting most of Algeria. Though the French responded with harsh repression, some areas — especially the northeastern mountains and regions near Tunisia and Morocco — became guerrilla strongholds the French could not control. To concentrate on keeping "French Algeria," France accepted the independence of Morocco and Tunisia in 1956. From that year, continuing until the following summer, the FLN launched the Battle of Algiers, trying to paralyze the French administration. To stop the insurgents' attacks, the French military tortured and summarily executed suspects. The entire FLN leadership was either eliminated or forced to flee. During the war, France conscripted 2 million soldiers to fight in Algeria and ultimately could not win. De Gaulle, back in power, allowed Algerians to decide their own status; some French settlers tried to prevent independence with terrorism, but in vain. In March 1962 the two sides signed the Evian Accords granting Algeria independence; its terms were put to a referendum in Algeria in July, with about 6 million votes in favor and 16,000 against. After 132 years of occupation, Algeria finally drove out the colonizers. It is estimated that during the eight-year war of independence, about 35,000 French died; estimates of Algerian deaths range from 300,000 to 1.5 million. Three million Algerians were displaced from their homeland, many never to return. In September 2018, President Macron publicly acknowledged systematic abuse by France during the Algerian war of independence. — Outlook, 2024, No. 35, "From 'French Algeria' to 'New Algeria'"

The second example is American imperialism's failure in Iraq and Afghanistan.

The American invasion of Afghanistan and the long occupation that followed not only inflicted enormous harm on Afghanistan; America itself spent enormous human and material resources and paid a heavy price. AP tallied the Afghan war in "lives and dollars": Time: 20 years, the longest war in American history. Lives: on the American side, nearly 2,500 soldiers and over 3,800 contractors dead, more than 20,000 wounded; on the Afghan side, 66,000 government soldiers and police killed, over 47,000 civilians killed. Money: over \$2.26 trillion, more than \$300 million a day. The final "fruits": failure to defeat the "enemy" Taliban — jokingly, "after 20 years, America successfully changed Afghanistan's regime from Taliban to Taliban"; failure to build a strong government army and national security forces; failure to establish Western democracy in Afghanistan; and in the end, a "disaster movie" of evacuation, mocked as another American "Saigon moment." — Li Qingsi, "A Cold Look at America: America's 20 Years in Afghanistan"

According to US Military Times, the "Costs of War" project estimates that, counting the costs of caring for Iraq war veterans and subsequent operations against ISIS in Iraq and Syria, the war's cost will balloon to \$2.89 trillion by 2050... The project's dollar figure includes \$862 billion in overseas contingency operations funding — the budget Congress used to support the post-9/11 global war on terror — and \$406 billion added to the Pentagon's base budget from 2003 to 2023. Researchers also counted \$233 billion in military health care and disability costs. Veterans care through 2050: \$1.1

trillion. The report listed some casualty figures: 4,600 service members, 15 Defense Department civilians, 3,650 contractors, 282 media workers, and 64 NGO humanitarian workers. In Syria: 19 contractors, 75 media workers, and 227 NGO workers killed. — "US media: the Iraq war has killed 550,000 people"

The most recent example is the Russia–Ukraine war. Though Ukraine has the support of the entire European and American military industry, in the early days, before aid arrived, it withstood Russia's surprise attack on its own, winning European and American support through its own tenacity.

At present, the whole of the Americas faces the threat of American military invasion, from Canada to Venezuela and even Brazil — all may face the test of war. If American imperialism suffers defeat in a war in the Americas, the risk of world war drops greatly.

(3) Anti-War Forces Within the Imperialist Countries

For the far-right clique inside an imperialist country to launch a war, it must first defeat the domestic anti-war forces. These consist of three parts:

1. the bourgeoisie already integrated into the global production chain (except the defense industry);
2. the liberals defending constitutionalism;
3. the left forces based on the working class (including immigrant workers) — democratic socialist or communist forces.

The bourgeoisie integrated into the global chain

Many American firms depend on imported goods. Tariff wars raise import costs, and domestic capacity cannot easily fill the gap, so these firms suffer heavy losses. If a full-scale war broke out, they would likely be devastated. This group is very sensitive to supply-chain disruption from great-power war and clearly opposes it.

According to CNBC, the US Chamber of Commerce sent a letter to the Trump administration urging it to immediately establish a "tariff exemption mechanism" to prevent the American economy from falling into recession and to avoid "irreparable harm" to small businesses. The White House rejected their request. The Chamber represents more than 3 million American businesses and organizations and is one of the world's largest and most influential business organizations. In the letter to Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent, Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick, and Trade Representative Greer, the Chamber said that given the negative impact of recent tariffs on the American economy, employers, and families, the swift and successful conclusion of negotiations with trading partners to rescind the tariffs imposed this year is critical. The Chamber demanded that the government "act immediately" to save American small businesses and avoid recession. Chamber President and CEO Clark said on May 1 that "over time, small businesses are increasingly threatened by rising costs and supply-chain disruptions, which would cause irreparable damage," and that negotiations take time — "many businesses simply cannot wait." The Chamber therefore demanded immediate action, including

automatically exempting all small importers from tariffs, to avoid recession. Source: The US Chamber of Commerce tells Trump: cut the tariffs quickly, the economy cannot hold

Though most Chamber members are small businesses, the decisive members are big corporations. The big firms of the developed countries all operate globally and are very unhappy with Trump's indiscriminate tariffs; but an individual firm, even a multinational, cannot contend with the state apparatus, so it can only express its views through the Chamber's name. Their role: on one hand, influencing public opinion through the media to pressure the government; on the other, lobbying Congress and the administration behind the scenes. And when firms close because of supply-chain disruption, the large-scale unemployment of workers also affects government decisions.

Before this, at least one lawsuit had already challenged some of Trump's tariffs. Last week, a nonprofit called the New Civil Liberties Alliance (NCLA) filed suit on behalf of a small business owner importing goods from China, arguing that the president had no legal authority to impose the tariffs on Chinese goods announced in February. The NCLA argues that IEEPA does not authorize the president to impose tariffs, and no president has ever tried to use IEEPA to do so. At present, most big-company CEOs are cautious about publicly opposing Trump's tariffs, fearing commercial retaliation by the president and his supporters. "No one wants to be a target" has become common wisdom. Through industry associations like the Chamber, firms may challenge government policy without putting their faces out front. Global affairs expert Sean West said: "If businesses dare not act themselves, they must force industry associations to take a tougher position than they want. Industry associations' role is no longer limited to gently slowing policy; they can become a channel for collective security of voice." Source: Opposing high tariffs! The US Chamber of Commerce considers suing the Trump administration

Still, the bourgeoisie can reduce the impact of trade wars or hot wars on their operations by various means: besides shifting some industries to low-risk countries like Southeast Asia, India, and Mexico, they can raise the local procurement share of their subsidiaries in each country. The transnational bourgeoisie's resistance to the war-making of imperialist countries is therefore weak and half-hearted. When war becomes unavoidable, they can even see business opportunities in it.

The liberals defending constitutionalism

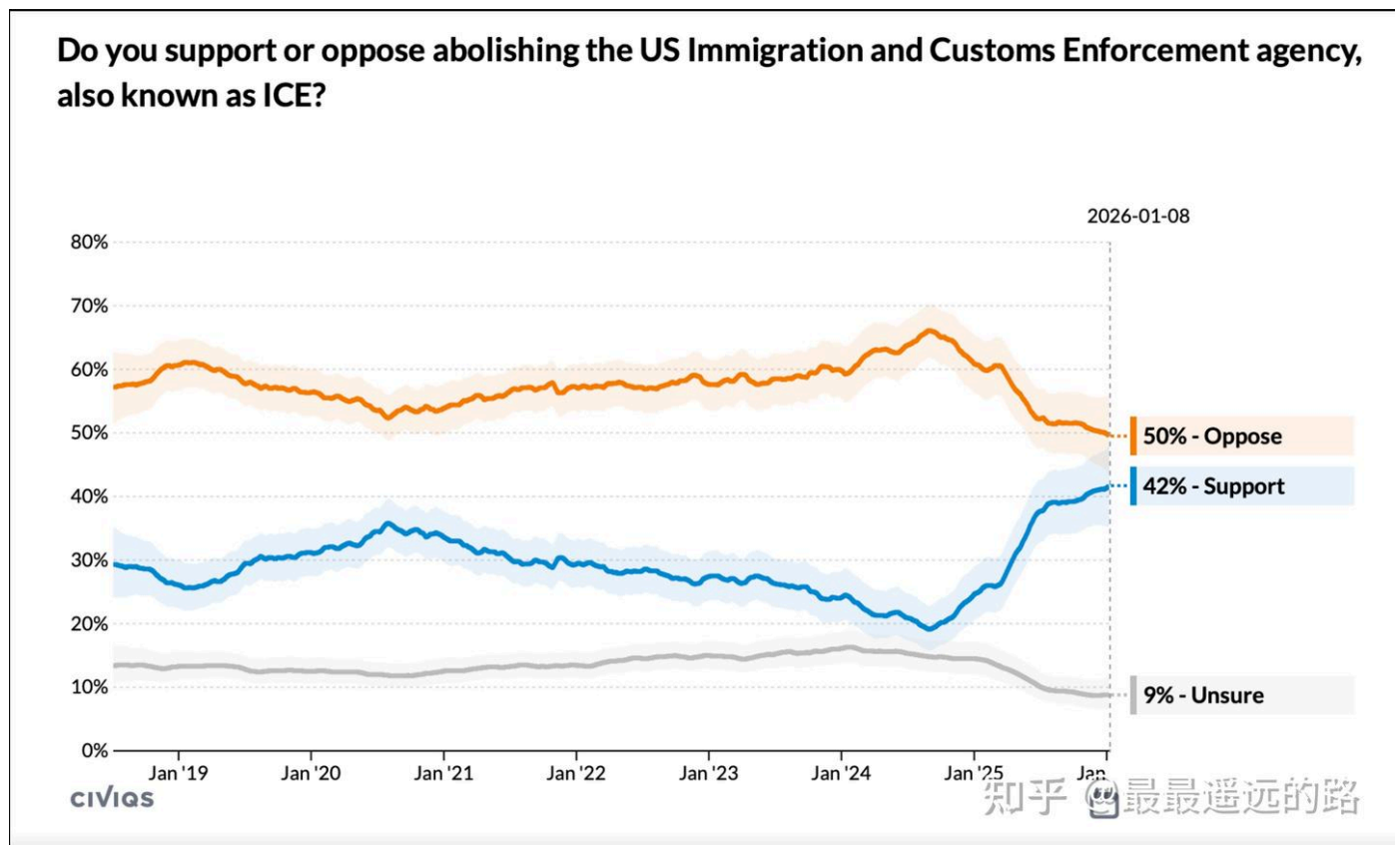
Unlike Hitler's Germany, America has a 200-year tradition of bourgeois constitutionalism. Small-scale intervention wars, because their impact on social life is limited, can be launched within the constitutional tradition; but a large-scale war, with its complex stakes and enormous involvement, is hard to pass through Congress and may require departing from bourgeois constitutionalism.

The Trump clique's rule frequently bypasses Congress, relying on presidential executive orders — the recent strike on Venezuela is an example. Democratic senators, joined by some Republicans, pushed

through a Senate resolution prohibiting Trump from unilaterally launching military operations in Venezuela.

The US Senate on Thursday voted to advance a resolution restricting the president from launching further attacks on Venezuela, which would prohibit Donald Trump from taking further military action against Venezuela without congressional authorization. In the Republican-majority Senate, all Democratic senators and five Republicans voted to advance the war-powers resolution, passing 52 to 47. Though the resolution is unlikely to become law, it warned of his expanding ambitions in the Western Hemisphere — even if passed by the House, it would need Trump's signature to take effect. Trump wrote on social media: "Republicans should be ashamed of those senators who just voted with the Democrats in an attempt to strip us of the power to defend the United States of America." Source: US Senate: restricting Trump's military strikes on Venezuela

After repeated revelations of ICE's violations of citizens' rights by the right-wing armed force under Trump's control, support for abolishing ICE rose to an all-time high, close to the level of support for ICE.



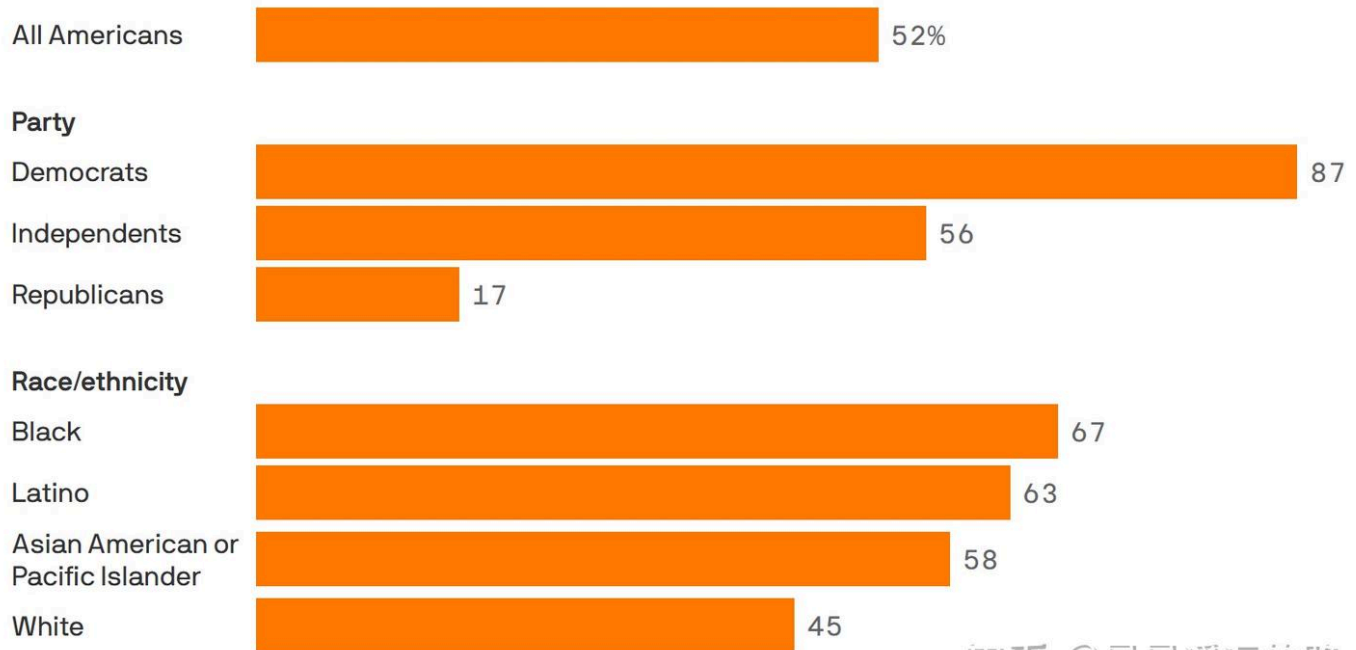
Source: <https://www.gelliottmorris.com/p/support-for-abolishing-ice-is-at>

More than half of Americans consider Trump a dangerous dictator who may destroy American democracy. This share reaches 87 percent among Democrats, only 17 percent among Republicans,

and over half among independents. This shows the Republican Party has seriously moved right; the defense of democratic constitutionalism is concentrated mainly in the Democratic Party.

Share who say they agree that President Trump is a "dangerous dictator whose power should be limited before he destroys American democracy"

Survey of 5,025 U.S. adults conducted Feb. 28 to March 20, 2025



Data: PRRI; Chart: Erin Davis / Axios Visuals

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Source: <https://www.axios.com/2025/04/29/prri-poll-most-americans-trump-dangerous-dictator>

The problem is that the Democratic Party, as a bourgeois party, excludes working-class politicians; even reformists like Sanders suffer repeated suppression. Following the negative lesson of the Weimar Republic and the positive lesson of the French Popular Front, if the broad anti-fascist left (including liberals) can unite, fascism can be defeated; otherwise it may win. But a broad-left alliance must be based on the working class's reform politics. Within the Democratic Party, the working-class reformism represented by Sanders, AOC, and others hopes for such an alliance, but this line is treated as heresy by the party's leadership. Still, as Trump's right-wing politics develops further, it is not wholly impossible that the liberals will be forced into alliance.

The Comintern, worried about the growing prevalence of fascist and authoritarian right-wing regimes in Europe, decided to abandon its hostility to social democracy and parliamentarism and adopt the "Popular Front" position. This advocated alliance with social democrats and sincere democratic middle-class republicans against the greater far-right threat. The Popular Front won the election of May 3, 1936, taking 386 of 608 seats. For the first time, the Socialists won more seats than the Radical-Socialists, and Socialist leader Léon Blum became France's first Socialist prime minister and

the first Jew to hold the office. The first Popular Front cabinet had 20 Socialists, 13 Radical-Socialists, and two Socialist-Republicans (no Communist ministers), and for the first time included three women (French women could not yet vote). Through the Matignon Agreements of 1936, the Popular Front government introduced new labor laws. On June 11, the Chamber of Deputies passed by 528 to 7 the laws establishing the 40-hour week, restoring civil-service pay, and two weeks' paid vacation. The Senate voted for them within a week. Source: [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Popular_Front_\(France\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Popular_Front_(France))

The left forces

In the last anti-fascist movement, the left — chiefly the Social Democrats and Communists — was the core force against fascism. The Social Democrats and Communists led the vast working class through the unions. In parliamentary elections and in street struggles alike, the left was the fascists' greatest adversary.

The left is the nemesis of fascism. In American politics, the only ones who dare openly call Trump a fascist are democratic socialists like AOC and others.

Mamdani maintains Trump a 'fascist' despite cordial White House meeting

The incoming NYC mayor says he still believes the US president is a fascist, two days after they had a friendly meeting.



US President Donald Trump, right, shakes hands with New York City Mayor-elect Zohran Mamdani during their November 21 meeting at the White House in Washington, DC, the United States [Jim Watson/AFP]

By News Agencies

23 Nov 2025

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New York City's Mayor-elect Zohran Mamdani says he still believes United States President Donald Trump is a fascist, despite a surprisingly warm meeting between the two politically polarised men at the White House this week.

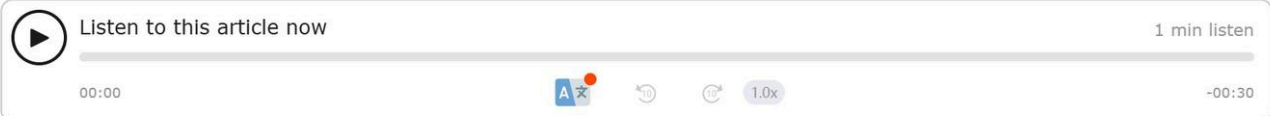
"That's something that I've said in the past; I say it today," Mamdani, a self-described democratic socialist, said about the Republican president in an interview aired on NBC News on Sunday.

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On America's military action against Venezuela, AOC directly called it an act of war violating international law, and Sanders pointed out it was an imperialist act. Left politicians daring to speak out publicly can play a great role in awakening the political consciousness of the people.

Madani condemns attack in Venezuela: 'Act of war, violation of international law'

Daniel Adelson, New York | 01.04.26 | 02:33



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New York Mayor Zohran Mamdani condemned the American attack in Venezuela. "A unilateral attack on a sovereign nation is an act of war and a violation of federal and international law. This overt pursuit of regime change not only affects those abroad, but has a direct impact on New York residents, including tens of thousands of Venezuelans who call this city home," he said.

Source: <https://www.ynetnews.com/article/32hatzgfk>

Bernie Sanders: US Attack on Venezuela Is Rank Imperialism

This brazen violation of international law gives a green light to any nation on earth that may wish to attack another country to seize their resources or change their governments.



By BERNIE SANDERS

Jan 03, 2026

[Common Dreams](#)

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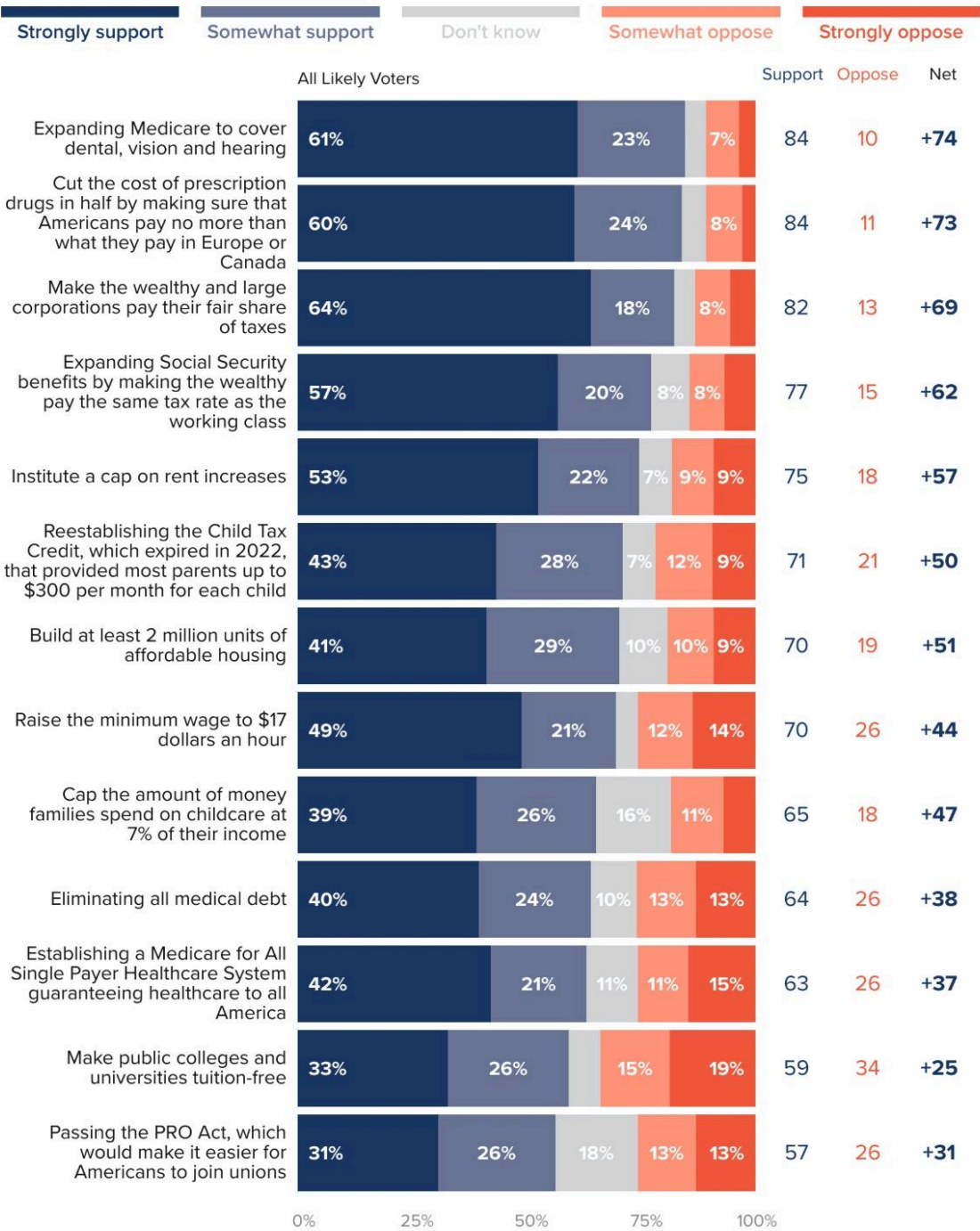


02:30

Editor's Note: The following statement by Sen. Bernie Sanders (I-Vt.) was issued Saturday, Jan. 3, 2026 following a press conference in which President Donald Trump confirmed Venezuelan President Nicolas Maduro, along with his wife, had been kidnapped by US forces and that going forward the US government would be "running" the country and seizing control of its natural resources, including vast oil reserves.

The American people are in fact increasingly welcoming left-progressive policies. In a 2024 cross-party survey, most policies of the social-democratic program won majority support. On issues closely tied to working-class life — health care, taxing the rich and big corporations, rent control — strong supporters exceeded 50 percent, with overall support above 70 percent, showing these have become consensus positions of the American working class. AOC's big win in New York is therefore no accident; it reflects the broader trend of the rise of left politics in American society. The social-democratic left and the fascist right are rising simultaneously; the struggle between them will be decisive.

Voters Support Progressive Policies



July 26–29, 2024 survey of 1,158 likely voters in AZ/GA/MI/PA/NV/WI

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DATA FOR PROGRESS

Source: <https://www.dataforprogress.org/insights/2024/8/6/democrats-should-run-on-a-progressive-economic-agenda-americans-are-ready>

(4) The South Persists in "Peace and Development"

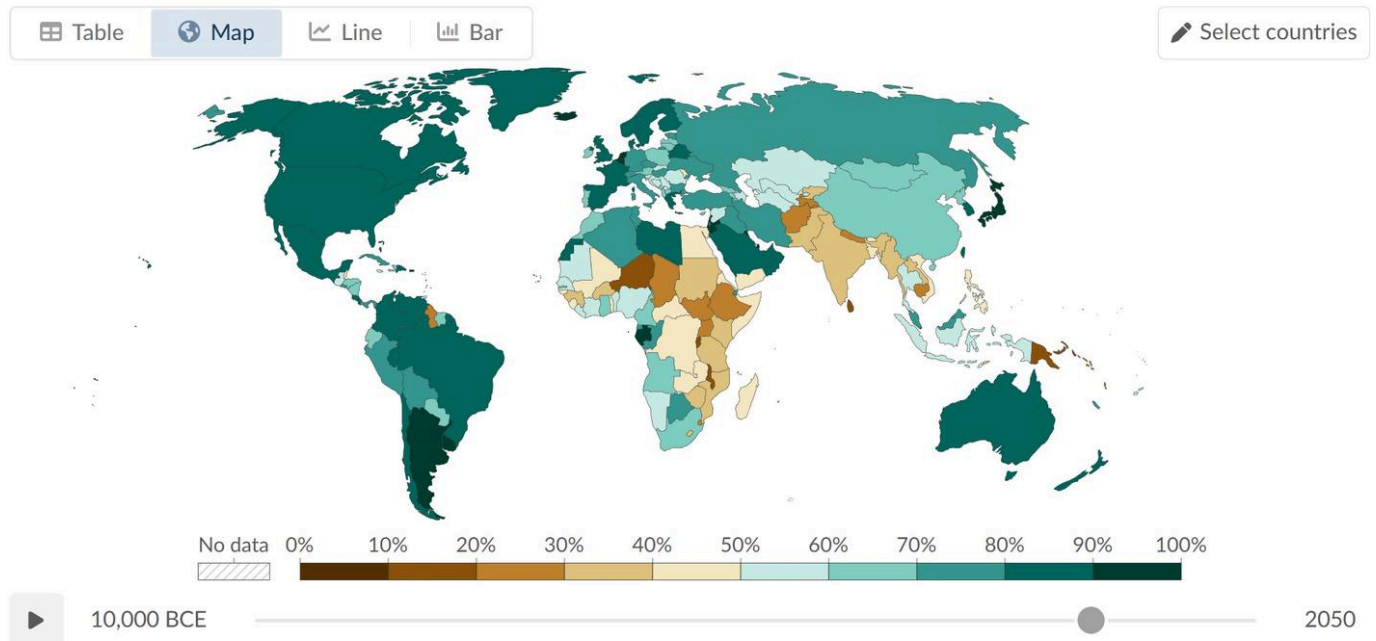
In the first part, we analyzed the postwar "peaceful alliance" between backward and advanced countries. The current risk of world war comes from contradictions among the industrialized

countries; but for the vast Southern countries, this "peaceful alliance" still has a deep foundation in reality. In Southeast Asia, South Asia, and Africa, about 3 billion rural people still await entry into the capitalist production system. For at least the next 30 years, this huge industrial reserve army remains the solid foundation of the "peaceful alliance" between the bourgeoisie of the backward countries and the bourgeoisie of the advanced industrial countries.

Share of the population living in urban areas, 2025

Share of the total population living in urban areas, given as estimates by HYDE until 2023 and UN projections through 2050, using the median fertility scenario for future urbanization trends.

Our World
in Data



Data source: United Nations, Department of Economic and Social Affairs, Population Division (2018); HYDE (2023) - [Learn more about this data](#)

Note: Because the estimates of city and metropolitan areas are based on national definitions of what constitutes a city or metropolitan area, cross-country comparisons should be made with caution.

OurWorldinData.org/urbanization | CC BY

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Global urbanization rate: much of Southeast Asia, South Asia, and Africa still has many countries with very low urbanization.
Source: <https://ourworldindata.org/urbanization#long-run-history-of-urbanization>

Against this background, it is easy to understand why the Southern countries persisted in globalization when the anti-globalization tide rose in the advanced industrial countries. China still calls itself part of the Global South because, when some former developed industrial countries withdrew from the alliance, China began forming "peaceful alliances" with other Southern countries, promoting a new round of China-led globalization.

Seeking development and rejuvenation is the common aspiration of the vast developing countries. Against the backdrop of de-globalization and rising trade protectionism, the world needs firmer confidence in economic globalization. Through high-quality Belt and Road cooperation and "greater BRICS cooperation," the Global South is increasingly injecting new momentum into a new type of globalization. Decades of development have proven that economic globalization benefits the rational

allocation of resources and factors of production worldwide, the global flow of capital and products, the global application of technology, and win-win outcomes for all participants. Facing the recent tide against globalization, Global South countries actively conduct multilateral cooperation, continuing to promote globalization through concrete actions. As market actors, Chinese enterprises increasingly participate in Global South cooperation, advancing economic globalization and industrialization through concrete practice. Dennis Depoux, co-president of the global management committee of the German consulting firm Roland Berger, said Chinese enterprises are increasingly participating in the industrialization of different regions of the world, especially in the Global South — not only advancing European industrial infrastructure, but also supporting regions with urgent industrialization needs such as the Middle East, Southeast Asia, South Asia, Central Asia, and Africa. Source: Pooling strength, seeking win-win — the "Global South" becomes a backbone force of economic globalization

For this reason, the Global South adheres to the general direction of "peace and development" and opposes war. War makes capital flee risk and reduce foreign investment, affecting the transfer of capital to the South and slowing the South's economic development.

In recent years, global geopolitical turbulence and frequent regional conflicts have focused the international community's attention on security issues, while attention to development issues and efforts to strengthen development cooperation have both sharply declined. The "Global South" calls on the international community to put development issues back at the center of the international agenda. South African President Ramaphosa said his country would use its 2025 G20 presidency to reaffirm development issues: "This is an opportunity to place the needs of Africa and other 'Global South' countries more firmly on the international development agenda." Emphasizing that development and security are inseparable, he actively defended international peace and security. Brazilian President Lula said: "Without peace, there is no sustainability or prosperity." Former Indonesian Foreign Minister Retno also noted that without peace, efforts to achieve global goals like sustainable development would be "dreams without reality." The current reality of frequent regional conflicts and turbulence not only causes enormous humanitarian disasters but also seriously diverts and consumes development resources. Former Indian National Security Adviser Shivshankar Menon believes the Ukraine crisis has diverted attention from more pressing global problems of this era. Colombian President Petro stressed that war diverts attention and resources from development goals and climate change. Source: An assessment of the "Global South's" international propositions and practice

Although the Southern countries themselves cannot use armed force to stop the military actions of the United States and other imperialist countries, they can remain neutral in an imperialist great war and ban the export of military-industrial products to the belligerents. At the same time, the South can support the small and medium countries invaded by imperialism, insisting on trading with them and supporting the people's resistance. The Southern countries are the majority of the world's population; in the short term this may not matter, but in the long run their voice can take effect.

(5) Nuclear Deterrence?

Because of nuclear weapons' enormous power, it is generally believed that conflicts between nuclear powers will not occur. The US and the Soviet Union, for example, avoided nuclear war in the 1960s. America and Russia have not been drawn into direct conflict over Ukraine, possibly related to Putin's constant nuclear threats. But India and Pakistan, two nuclear states, did go to war — so this principle does not seem to hold forever.

Take India and Pakistan: each believes the other will not be the first to use nuclear weapons, because both have second-strike capability. Precisely for this reason, two nuclear powers can go to war and fight with conventional weapons. But from existing experience, the Indian and Pakistani governments have both actively cooled tensions to prevent war from expanding.

Based on India's and Pakistan's nuclear-capable delivery vehicles, the Federation of American Scientists estimated that by 2024 the two countries may have built 172 and 170 nuclear warheads respectively... In 2024, the Indian military publicized a doctrine of limited conventional war called the "Cold Start Doctrine" — India could launch a rapid, limited conventional strike or invasion of Pakistani territory without triggering Pakistani nuclear retaliation. In response to this new doctrine, Pakistan introduced the "Full-Spectrum Deterrence" doctrine. As described by Lt. Gen. Kidwai, long-time head of Pakistan's Strategic Plans Division, the doctrine requires Pakistan's nuclear weapons to have the full spectrum from tactical to strategic, for strikes of varying destructive power; the full-spectrum range from "zero meters to 2,750 km" to cover all of India; and the full spectrum of targets from battlefield to city, to penetrate India's missile defense and air defense systems... On the whole, though the names of the two countries' nuclear deterrence doctrines differ, both are essentially strategies of "minimum nuclear deterrence": they do not seek war-fighting capability, only second-strike capability. As long as one side has second-strike (or retaliation) capability, nuclear weapons can play a huge role in deterring invasion and safeguarding core national interests. India and Pakistan are currently in a state of mutual nuclear deterrence or mutually assured destruction: neither is confident of eliminating all the other's nuclear forces in a first strike; after absorbing a first strike, one side's nuclear forces can inflict unacceptable damage by retaliating against political, economic, and industrial centers and other value targets. Out of fear of the consequence of unacceptable damage, neither wants to be drawn into a full nuclear conflict, so the two countries have considerable strategic stability. Although nuclear deterrence can maintain strategic stability, it cannot deter non-strategic local conventional conflicts. In low-intensity local conventional conflicts, neither side feels it has interests requiring the use of the "ultimate weapon," neither believes the other will use nuclear weapons, and both know that any use of nuclear weapons risks uncontrollable escalation. Thus low-intensity local conventional conflict is a gray zone where nuclear deterrence cannot directly function; what matters there is often non-nuclear factors — diplomacy, willpower, conventional force. This is why India and Pakistan, despite a degree of "mutually assured destruction," still have local conventional clashes. Though nuclear deterrence cannot deter local conventional conflict, under its effect the two sides will be more restrained and

cautious in such conflicts, trying to avoid escalation to large-scale conventional war and to avoid touching the nuclear-use threshold. Source: Shi Jianbin, PhD, Strategic Research Center, China Academy of Engineering Physics, "Can mutual nuclear deterrence effectively stop India–Pakistan escalation?"

India and Pakistan both belong to the Global South, and both currently make development their main task. In the capitalist world-system they have room to develop, so they are unwilling to fight big wars. But for countries that have already completed industrialization, whose room to develop within the global capitalist order is being squeezed, views on nuclear deterrence are less certain. For instance, Ivan Timofeev, Director General of the Russian International Affairs Council, writing on the Valdai Club website, doubts whether nuclear weapons can really stop war from escalating.

There is no guarantee that escalation from conventional strikes to tactical strikes, and then to strategic nuclear strikes, will be under Washington's control. The United States could also be the loser. Nuclear war has no winners. Unless one side has a fatal weakness. The problem is that relying on the adversary's weakness can be mistaken and catastrophic, both for oneself and for others. Clearly, both sides realize that if Russia and NATO enter direct military conflict, it will be a total defeat. Such a confrontation would require fundamental changes in all spheres and bring losses Europe has not known for a long time. But history has many examples where the prospect of losing and breaking with the conventional did not prevent historical disasters and major conflicts. The recurrence of extreme eras cannot be ruled out. Nuclear weapons remain the cornerstone of deterrence. But the taboo on their use and the ability to prevent aggression are once again in question. Source: International affairs | The nuclear deterrence dilemma: risks and uncertainties of Russia–NATO confrontation

Nuclear weapons only make the launching and escalation of war more cautious. Once a political clique takes the militarist road, nuclear weapons can neither prevent war from breaking out nor prevent its escalation. If a world war becomes a nuclear war, it will be an extremely terrifying prospect — at least for the residents of the great cities of the belligerent countries.

IV. The Prospects of War

Does the American strike on Venezuela, the territorial claims on Canada and Greenland, and the threat of armed attack on Mexico indicate that the situation of world war is forming?

特朗普：很快打击墨西哥境内

农民日报 2026年1月10日 18:27 北京

据西班牙《阿贝赛报》网站1月9日报道，美国总统特朗普1月8日表示，**针对墨西哥境内贩毒集团的军事行动“很快”将启动。**

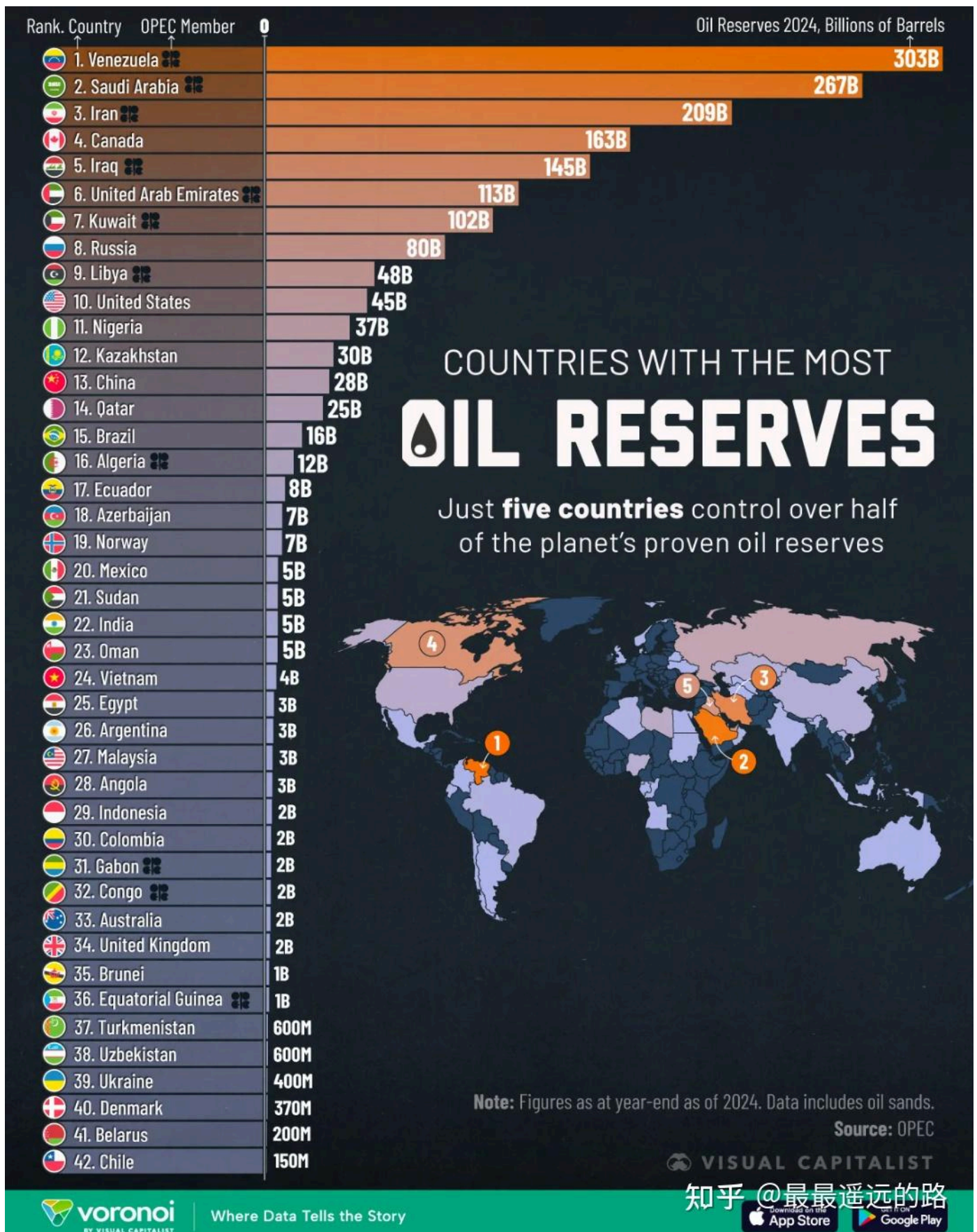
报道说，特朗普在接受福克斯新闻频道采访时表示：“**我们将开始对贩毒集团实施地面打击。**”与此同时，美墨两国关系正日趋紧张。

特朗普说：“贩毒集团正在操控墨西哥。目睹该国发生的一切令人痛心。但贩毒集团正在掌控这个国家，每年在我国境内杀害25万至30万人。” 知乎 @最最遥远的路

<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/vjLhOImpckGr85Mbv5Nq6g>

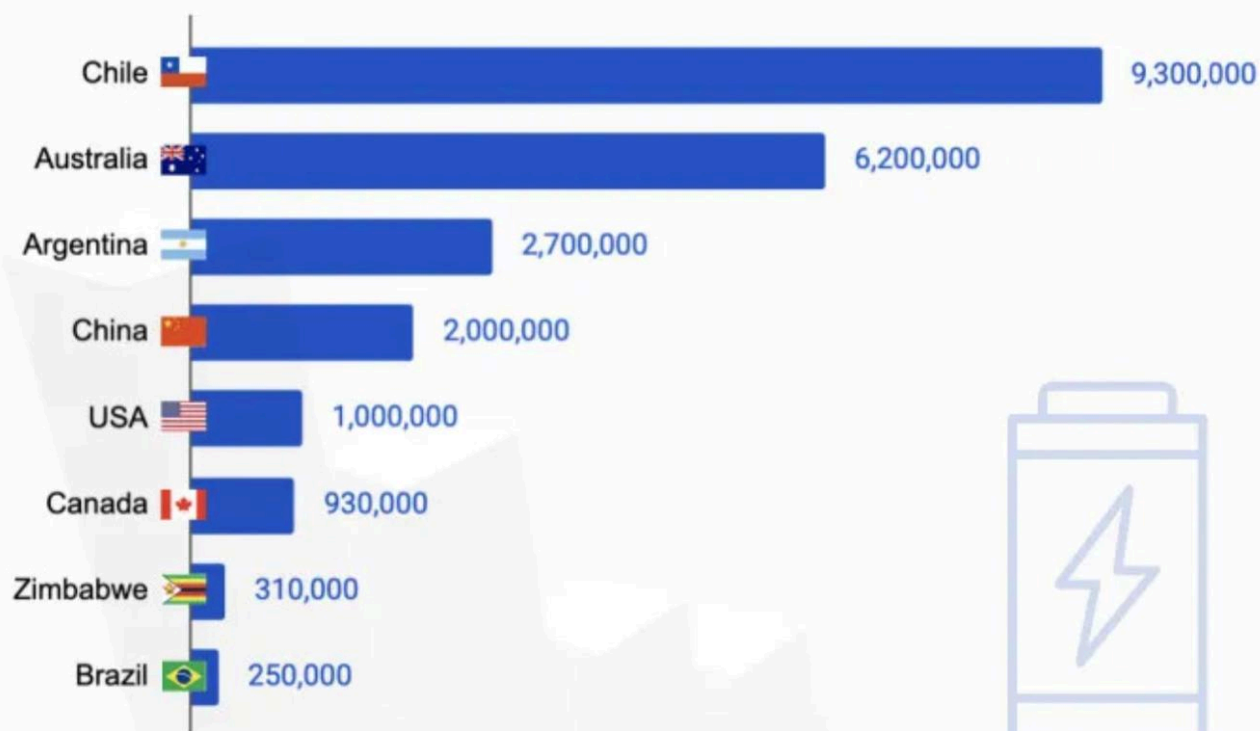
It may still be too early to say so. America's current military industry cannot support large-scale war, let alone a full-scale war with the industrial hegemon. The strategy of the Trump clique, as its published report indeed says, is first to consolidate the Americas, develop military power, control the Middle East, stabilize East Asia, and then contend for the world.

America's targets are two regions: the Americas and the Middle East. By controlling these two regions, America can control the world's most important bulk-commodity trade, gaining the initiative in the game with the industrial hegemon.



World oil reserves: the top 10 countries, except Russia, are all in the Americas and the Middle East

Countries With World's Biggest Lithium Reserves



Source: US Geological Survey

Note: 2022 data in million tonnes

INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS TIMES

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The countries with the largest lithium reserves are mostly in the Americas and Australia

Conversely, if the Trump clique cannot complete the first step — controlling the Americas and the Middle East — it lacks the conditions to launch a world war directly. Since the Middle Eastern and American countries are deeply militarily dependent on the US, their governments will find it hard to withstand American pressure head-on; a situation of several American countries being "hijacked" by the US is quite possible. When America completes this round of arms expansion and restores its large-scale war capability, its control may turn into deep control. Notably, America's military-industrial expansion is very fast: monthly production of 155mm howitzer shells has grown from 14,000 before the Russia-Ukraine war to 40,000, reaching 100,000 in 2026. Capacity for missiles,

fighters, and all kinds of weapons and ammunition is expanding. If the Trump clique's plan is implemented, America will likely fight a big war in Latin America or the Middle East in the early 2030s. If the American AI bubble bursts and an economic crisis breaks out, war will come earlier.

So the current front line consists of three aspects: the struggle within America against the Trump clique, the struggle in the Americas against American annexation and semi-colonial control, and the struggle in the Middle East against American hegemonic interference. American imperialism is certainly strong, but the forces opposing it are also broadly sourced; in sustained struggle, they may coalesce into ever stronger force and ultimately defeat US imperialism.

If world war unfortunately breaks out, what then? That topic is beyond the scope of this article. By the experience of the twentieth century, world war leads to the collapse and disintegration of the capitalist order of rule; what grows out of the ruins will be another, better social system. As Chairman Mao said, "When the world is in great disorder, the situation is excellent" — of course in the dialectical sense. The working people and people of conscience of the whole world should actively oppose war and prevent the world from being swallowed by the flames of fascist militarism.

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